

The art of attraction: Decoding dynamics of entrepreneurs presentation experience in reward-based crowdfunding

Mohammadreza Meigounpoory^a, Pouria Rad^{b,*}, Mohsen Jozani^c, Gianluca Zanella^d

^a Faculty of Entrepreneurship, University of Tehran, No. 18, North Kargar St, Tehran, Iran

^b School of Computer and Cyber Sciences, Augusta University, 1120 15th Street, Augusta, GA 30912, USA

^c Fowler College of Business, San Diego State University, 5500 Campanile Dr, San Diego, CA 92182, USA

^d School of Computer and Cyber Sciences, Augusta University, 1120 15th Street, Augusta, GA 30912, USA

ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Creator-level factors
Reward-based crowdfunding
Speech acts
Visual branding
Community Engagement

ABSTRACT

Crowdfunding outcomes depend not only on projects but on how creators present themselves. We study creator-level factors in the "About the Creator" section on Kickstarter using a large longitudinal dataset, combining speech act analysis of biographies, automated classification of avatar type and quality, and measures of on-platform engagement. Expressive wording that signals ownership and inclusion is positively associated with funding, whereas several commissive framings that emphasize need, process, or persistence are negatively associated, and casual interjections are also detrimental. Higher quality avatars are beneficial, while substituting a logo for a face is associated with poorer outcomes. Engagement matters, as replying to comments and a richer history of backing other projects are positively related to funding, while a passive social media link shows no reliable relationship. An integrated creator-level model that pools these cues improves explanatory power beyond standard campaign-level factors, and a comparison of the highest and lowest scoring biographies by our speech acts index indicates materially better funding performance for the former. The study foregrounds the entrepreneur as the locus of trust formation and offers a portable toolkit and practical guidance for improving creator self-presentation.

1. Introduction

Securing funds is a critical step in any entrepreneurial venture, and reward-based crowdfunding (RBCF) has become a prominent model for entrepreneurs to validate and launch their creative ideas directly to the public (E. R. Mollick, 2012; Poetz & Schreier, 2012). In rewards-based crowdfunding, backers do not receive company equity or debt in return for their contributions. Instead, they are promised a "reward," which can be the product being developed, a chance to be involved in the design process, or a small thank-you gift. The rewards are often organized into tiers, with different levels of contribution unlocking different perks. An investor's (Backer) decision to support a project (Campaign) is driven by both external rewards (extrinsic motivation) and psychological rewards like altruism and community involvement (intrinsic motivation) (Hohen et al., 2025). Additionally, cognitive biases and social proof influence the backer's risk perception and, in turn, their choice to support the campaign (Zheng et al., 2014). Unlike

traditional financing routes, crowdfunding heavily emphasizes trust on the campaign, which depends upon both project and entrepreneur characteristics (Belleflamme et al., 2014; Messeni Petruzzelli et al., 2019; E. Mollick, 2014). Indeed, campaign-specific elements such as product prototypes, rewards, funding goals, title, updates, and social media promotion explain the success of a campaign (Belleflamme et al., 2014; Cordova et al., 2015; Elkhidir, 2017; Hsieh et al., 2019; Jozani et al., 2022; Yuan et al., 2016; M. Zhou et al., 2018). A key driver of backer trust and interest is the entrepreneur's ability to create compelling narratives (Cappa et al., 2021), exhibit transparency, and show unwavering commitment to the project (Gerber & Hui, 2013; Koch & Cheng, 2016). Perhaps, the information about the entrepreneur as human asset is causally crucial to secure early-stages funding from professional investors (Bernstein et al., 2017).

Information such as a biographical description (W. Wang et al., 2020) or a personal picture (Broeder & Remers, 2018) can build trust and legitimacy, thus positively influencing the decision-making process

* Corresponding author.

E-mail addresses: meigounpoory@ut.ac.ir (M. Meigounpoory), peslamirad@augusta.edu (P. Rad), mjozani@sdsu.edu (M. Jozani), gzanella@augusta.edu (G. Zanella).

<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijinfomgt.2025.102998>

Received 12 October 2024; Received in revised form 26 October 2025; Accepted 31 October 2025

Available online 6 November 2025

0268-4012/© 2025 The Author(s). Published by Elsevier Ltd. This is an open access article under the CC BY license (<http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>).

of investors or customers. Indeed, the role of the creator human capital has emerged as a critical, yet underexplored, determinant of online projects success, particularly in crowdfunding projects which often involve considerable uncertainty during their conceptual and testing stages (S. Chen et al., 2023; E. Mollick, 2014). In classic venture financing, the question whether investors fund the project or the entrepreneur has been already settled. As RBCF gains popularity as a new form of venture funding, it is crucial to test whether backers fund the idea or the creator. With this research question in mind, this research aims to understand how creator-level factors influence backer perceptions and funding outcomes.

Our study delves into how these textual, visual, and community engagement elements, particularly those related to the creator, affect the likelihood of achieving funding goals. Specifically, we examine how the creator's verbal and visual branding cues, such as persuasive speech acts, high-quality images or logos along with their community engagement through backer interactions, past project support, and social media presence, can impact crowdfunding fundraising outcomes. By focusing on these creator-centric factors, we aim to provide a broader understanding of how strategic communication and presentation tactics can optimize funding success. Building on this foundation, we propose a framework to explain the decision-making process of RBCF backers, as shown in Fig. 1. This framework recognizes decision-making as a sequential process. It starts with the landing page, where visual and textual elements capture the backer's attention, move through an assessment of the campaign details, and culminate in a review of the creator's profile before the final funding decision is made. For creators, the challenge extends beyond merely attracting clicks or visits to their campaign page; it requires converting this initial interest into tangible funding commitments. This conversion is achieved through a combination of persuasive communication, strategic self-presentation, and trust-building elements that resonate with potential backers (Strausz, 2017).

To explore these mechanisms, our study addresses the following research questions: (1) How do different types of speech acts, particularly commissive and expressive speech acts, used in the creator's biography section impact crowdfunding success? (2) What is the role of visual branding, such as using professional logos instead of personal photographs for their avatar, in enhancing the perceived credibility and funding outcomes of campaigns? Additionally, how does the quality of these avatars will affect the fundraising outcomes? (3) How does a creator's prior engagement in the crowdfunding community, including their interactions with potential backers, past contributions and social media presence, influence backer trust and the likelihood of achieving funding goals?

To address these research questions, we apply Speech Act Theory (Austin & Warnock, 1962; Searle, 1969) to analyze the role of different communication strategies in crowdfunding. This theory has been instrumental in understanding how creators' language choices influence trust and engagement in digital marketing and social media contexts (A. Chen et al., 2023; Ludwig & de Ruyter, 2016). Then, we draw from visual branding and social proof literature to examine how visual elements like logos for avatars and social media connections serve as cues for credibility and professionalism in online environments (Gerber & Hui, 2013; Koch & Cheng, 2016; Zribi & Khoufi, 2022).

This study focuses on a Kickstarter platform, where our dataset comprises 9907 crowdfunding campaigns launched on Kickstarter between 2009 and 2025. The project failure rate on the average rate is 42.28 % for the Kickstarter platform (Kickstarter, 2025), however in this paper we will study different aspects of entrepreneurial presentation that can boost fundraising probability of RBCF campaigns. To assess the impact of creators' written verbal cues on investor trust and persuasion, we use Linguistic Inquiry and Word Count (LIWC). To examine the visual cues, we first extract generic aesthetic scores for sharpness and contrast from all avatar photos. Next, we employ HAAR Cascade object detection to identify the presence of logos in creators' avatars to distinguish between a logo and a picture depicting a human face. We assume the face belongs to the creator. By focusing on creators' biographies and self-presentations, this study provides a novel lens for understanding how specific elements of self-presentation can drive backer engagement and funding outcomes. Additionally, our methodology has broader potential applications beyond crowdfunding, including assessing the effectiveness of organizational communication strategies and community engagement on various platforms.

Our study contributes to the literature on crowdfunding by focusing on creator-specific variables. First, our findings suggest that expressive speech acts, such as using inclusive language in the 'About the Creator' section, are crucial in fostering a sense of community and shared identity among backers, enhancing engagement and support for crowdfunding campaigns. Second, the creator's use of a personal headshot of themselves or their teams instead of a logo for their avatars can be a strong visual cue that enhances perceived professionalism and trustworthiness, positively impacting funding success. Additionally, if creators choose to use a logo, having a high-quality image affects fundraising positively, indicating that quality comes first, by whatever path an entrepreneur chooses. Third, a creator's active participation within the crowdfunding community, specifically by interacting with potential backers in the comment section of their campaigns and backing other projects, serves as an important indicator of social capital and reciprocity, significantly impacting campaign outcomes.

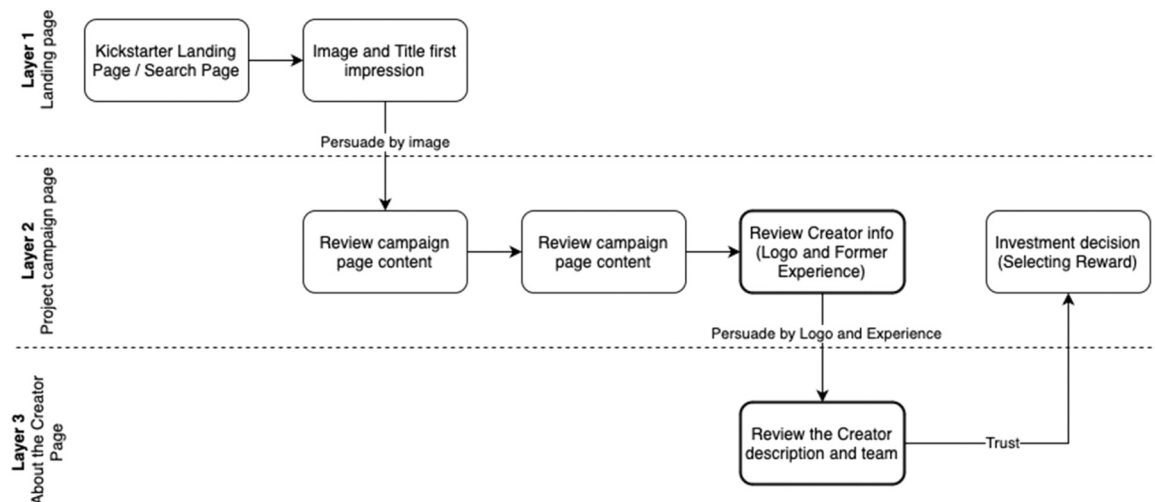


Fig. 1. The decision-making process in Reward-based Crowdfunding.

The paper is structured as follows: 2 reviews relevant studies to identify critical research gaps in the literature. 3 introduces the theoretical background and proposes research hypotheses. 4 presents the methodology, including details on dataset acquisition, pre-processing techniques, and methods for feature extraction and selection. 5 summarizes the results of the empirical analysis. Finally, 6 discusses the theoretical and practical implications and suggests potential directions for future research.

2. Literature review

2.1. Creator-centric factors in crowdfunding

Past studies on the success of crowdfunding have predominantly concentrated on project attributes such as team characteristics, project characteristics, social influence, user-generated content, financing objectives, campaign length, and forms of incentives (Alhammad et al., 2022). Many authors contrasted traditional financing with alternative methods like crowdfunding and identified these factors as crucial in assessing the probability of a campaign achieving its financial goal, noting that the ease of application and direct interaction with backers can significantly influence campaign success (Belleflamme et al., 2014; Hsieh et al., 2019; E. Mollick, 2014; Obiora & Csordás, 2017). However, more recent research has shifted attention toward the role of the creator (Kuppuswamy & Bayus, 2018a). Creator-centric aspects refer to the many characteristics and behaviors of the project creator that can substantially influence the success of a crowdfunding campaign. These factors encompass the creator's credibility, social media presence, previous experience with crowdfunding, and the efficacy of their communication techniques. Studies have demonstrated that creators who portray themselves as reliable and competent are more inclined to attract support from backers. Creators who have a track record of successfully funding past projects or who regularly interact with their community are more likely to instill higher trust and confidence in potential supporters (Gerber et al., 2012; Kuppuswamy & Bayus, 2018b; N. Wang et al., 2018).

While previous research has made strides in understanding certain aspects of creator traits, these studies have largely overlooked the combined impact of biographical elements, social engagement (such as backing other projects), and communication strategies in the context of RBCF. For example, prior research has examined elements like professional visual branding (e.g., logos, consistent color schemes) in equity-based crowdfunding (Koch & Cheng, 2016; Mahmood et al., 2019), but there has been insufficient emphasis on the interaction of these elements with the creator's overall social media presence, previous entrepreneurial experience, and community engagement in RBCF. Moreover, while the function of speech acts in communication has been examined, current research frequently overlooks how many categories of speech acts (e.g., commissive, expressive) jointly enhance trust and engagement among supporters (Pennebaker et al., 1999). By filling in these gaps, our research provides fresh perspectives on the combined influence of these elements on crowdfunding results, improving academic knowledge and providing helpful advice for platforms and authors trying to maximize campaign success.

2.2. Communication strategies in crowdfunding

The conceptual framework of speech act theory helps one to realize how language not only offers means of information transmission but also of action implementation. This phenomenon is particularly important for the study of communication methods in crowdfunding, where the degree of success can be greatly affected by the efficacy of campaign language. Every speech act, the theory, is either locutionary, which is the act of saying something; illocutionary, meaning the intended objective of the utterance; or perlocutionary, meaning the effect on the listener (Austin & Warnock, 1962; Searle, 1969). This approach enables

a comprehensive investigation of how campaign producers employ language to captivate, convince, and inspire potential supporters. Properly communicating the value and confidence of their concept to possible sponsors is one of the key challenges creators confront in crowdfunding. The deliberate use of language turns into a necessary tool for this effort. In this setting, commissive and expressive verbal behaviors are rather important. Making pledges and commitments, among other commissive acts, generates a responsibility for the speaker to engage in a particular action going forward. Developing credibility requires these deeds. On the other hand, expressive acts help the speaker to communicate her feelings and attitudes, therefore strengthening the relationship with the listener (Janson & Woo, 1996; Roberts, 2013; Searle, 1969).

Upon reviewing previous research on this topic, certain papers are more pertinent to our study than others. Researchers examined the influence of various speech actions employed by streamers in e-commerce livestreams on client purchasing intentions. Directive, aggressive, and declarative speaking acts substantially enhanced client interest, word of mouth, and purchase intention (A. Chen, Wang, et al., 2023). This research highlights the importance of guiding entrepreneurs' speech acts to enhance consumer engagement and sales. Consequently, two other studies explored the application of Speech Act Theory in social media communication, emphasizing the importance of both content and style in interpreting customer perceptions and intentions (Argyris et al., 2021; Ludwig & de Ruyter, 2016). Both indicate that analyzing speech behaviors in online platforms can yield significant signals into future customer trust and involvement. A study on the linguistic characteristics of marketing content in social commerce indicated that self-referencing and detailing (micro-level), argument structure (macro-level), and linguistic style matching (meta-level) substantially affect consumer purchasing behavior (F. Wang et al., 2023). Additionally, another researcher examined the impact of linguistic style in online product reviews on customer judgments of sincerity and deception (Ansari & Gupta, 2021). Utilizing Speech Act Theory, this research created a model for evaluating reviews by considering contextual embedding, argument structuring, and non-verbal clues. According to their research, text pieces with less contextual embedding and argument structuring are seen as more dishonest. This underscores the potential significance of linguistic cues in influencing backers' impressions, particularly in the context of crowdfunding, where trust plays a vital role (Agrawal et al., 2015; E. Mollick, 2014).

Although the importance of these speech acts is recognized, their strategic use in crowdfunding is still quite understudied. This disparity suggests the need for more focused research on the effects of several speech acts used in various parts of a crowdfunding project on backer behavior and campaign outcomes. Furthermore, it is not entirely clear how commissive and expressive speech interact in crowdfunding. Understanding how different linguistic expressions work together to build trust and involvement could provide valuable information for people in charge of developing campaigns. For example, a campaign combining sincere expressions of emotion with strong pledges could be more interesting than one, depending just on one strategy. This paper will address this gap by providing a more thorough understanding of how creators could maximize their communication techniques to produce desired results.

2.3. Visual elements and credibility

Current research has emphasized the importance of visual elements and credibility attributes in the efficacy of crowdfunding initiatives. In equity-based crowdfunding, researchers established that professionally designed logos and cohesive visual branding substantially improve the perceived professionalism and legitimacy of projects (Koch & Cheng, 2016). In the same way, another study discovered that even low-validity visual indicators, such as basic logos, might impact backers' impressions of venture innovation, leading to influencing their financing choices

(Mahmood et al., 2019). This indicates that backers depend on heuristic cognitive shortcuts that influence decision-making based on the ease of processing visual components. However, both of these research focus on equity-based or other non-reward crowdfunding models and overlook how these visual elements operate in the context of RBCF, where backers face different risks and levels of engagement. Backers of RBCF deal with many difficulties, such as not being able to personally contact with tangible rewards prior to pledging. While Studies predominantly emphasize general visual components instead of investigating the particular dynamics of logos and personal branding in RBCF, they revealed that visuals in crowdfunding campaigns influence backers' initial perceptions, assisting in lowering perceived risks and impacting perceived empathy and credibility, especially in the first review stage of projects demonstrated in Fig. 1 (S. Chen, Wang, et al., 2023; Guo et al., 2022; E. Mollick, 2014). Nonetheless, little has been studied on how these visual signals interact with other important elements, including the creator's community involvement, social media presence, and past experience.

Research has shown that consistent branding can enhance perceived professionalism and trustworthiness, which are both critical for attracting and retaining backer support. Consistent branding can enhance perceived professionalism and trustworthiness, which are critical for attracting and retaining backers' attention in competitive, algorithmically mediated environments where presentation quality drives exposure (Belleflamme et al., 2014; Jozani et al., 2023; Koch & Cheng, 2016). Some studies suggest that regular branding reinforces a professional image, while others emphasize that such visual cues can influence backers' trust by signaling reliability. Furthermore, visual uniformity in campaign materials is often perceived as a marker of authenticity and consistency, reinforcing backer confidence (Belleflamme et al., 2014; Cialdini, 1993; Gerber et al., 2012; Yuan et al., 2016). Though a lot of research has already been done, most studies have concentrated on single visual elements in isolation without thinking through how these elements interact with creator-centric elements, including experience and community involvement. Particularly in high-risk forms of fundraising like RBCF, our study extends this limited emphasis and looks at how visual aspects mix with innovative traits to affect backer perceptions of trust and campaign success. Additionally, we investigate the specific effect of using a logo for the creator's avatar instead of a personal image, exploring how this choice impacts backer trust and funding decisions. This insight is the foundation for the conceptual framework and hypothesis development discussed later in this study.

2.4. Creator engagement and social proof

With studies showing the value of social interactions and online communication in enhancing campaign success, these exchanges help creators build confidence and a good reputation among possible backers, therefore affecting the success of the campaign (Borst et al., 2018; Colombo et al., 2015; Zanella & Renard, 2022). However, most of this study has been on equity-based or subscription-based crowdfunding models, leading to a lack of knowledge of how these dynamics operate in RBCF, where backers evaluate legitimacy using another set of cues. Researchers have examined the impact of social interaction on crowdfunding success, emphasizing comment quantity, emotional tone, and reply rates, and have discovered an inverted U-shaped correlation. Although social involvement is beneficial, excessive interaction may inundate supporters and reduce efficacy (Jia et al., 2024). Furthermore, research on subscription-based platforms highlights that a robust social identity and regular engagement enable authors to foster more profound ties with their audience (Wu & Li, 2023). Prior research has recognized that creators' active engagement in the crowdfunding ecosystem, including participation in other projects, can foster a feeling of community and reciprocity that is valued by backers (Kuppuswamy & Bayus, 2018a; Zheng et al., 2014). That said, these studies predominantly

address creator involvement in broad terms, failing to explore how this reciprocal interaction and support of other projects directly influence RBCF or interacts with other creator-related elements.

Moreover, choosing appropriate communication channels is critical in maximizing campaign effectiveness. Research on the efficacy of various Internet communication methods in converting followers into financial backers presents empirical data emphasizing that email is the most efficient media, followed by Facebook, while Twitter is the least efficient (Tosatto et al., 2022). This highlights the importance of not only engaging with backers but also selecting the right tools for communication to maintain strong social connections. Further studies highlight that both project-level characteristics, such as campaign presentation, goal setting, and the nature of the product, and creator-level characteristics, including the creator's social capital, reputation, and engagement, play critical roles in crowdfunding success, particularly in RBCF (Shi et al., 2023). Their findings emphasize that creators who effectively leverage their social capital by engaging with a broad audience and building meaningful relationships significantly improve their chances of reaching their funding goals. This reinforces the idea that both social and online communication are pivotal for campaign success, particularly in fostering trust and credibility.

In addition, integrating social media into crowdfunding efforts is crucial for expanding a project's reach and demonstrating transparency. Research shows that visibility on social networks enhances trust and credibility in online transactions, making creators' social media presence an important signal for backers (Lee & Hong, 2016; E. Mollick, 2014). Despite these insights, prior research has not examined how these social interaction elements interact with success in RBCF. Our study fills this gap by exploring how creator engagement, specifically backing other projects and integrating social media connection in the creator's biography section, shapes backer perceptions and campaign success. In RBCF, where social cues are critical, this integrated approach provides a comprehensive understanding of how creators can build trust. These realizations will provide the foundation for our hypothesis in the next parts of the paper when we investigate the influence of these elements on the probability of reaching financial targets.

3. Conceptual framework and hypothesis development

3.1. Speech acts

Speech Act Theory posits that language transmits information and performs actions that shape social realities (Austin & Warnock, 1962; Searle, 1969). It broadly identifies five categories of illocutionary acts: assertive, directives, commissives, expressives, and declaratives, each serving distinct communicative functions. In the RBCF context, commissive and expressive acts are particularly salient because creators must overcome two core challenges: building trust and fostering emotional engagement (Ghobadi, 2023; E. Mollick, 2014). In short, Commissive acts (e.g., promises, pledges) signal accountability and future orientation, thereby reducing perceived risk (Blue et al., 2020), while Expressive acts (e.g., gratitude, enthusiasm) reveal emotional investment and create a sense of connection that can bolster backer support (Anglin et al., 2018; Paxton et al., 2020).

Commissive speech acts, such as promises, offers, and pledges, bind the speaker to a future course of action, creating a sense of obligation and accountability (Austin & Warnock, 1962). This is especially important in RBCF, where backers seek assurance that the project creator will fulfill their promises, making the perceived reliability of the creator a pivotal factor in funding decisions. Research in various domains, including marketing and consumer behavior, supports the effectiveness of commissive acts in influencing audience perceptions and actions. For instance, in advertising, the use of promises and commitments can significantly boost consumer trust and engagement by conveying a sense of reliability and dedication to quality (Ansari & Gupta, 2021; STRIZHKOVA et al., 2018). This can be paralleled in RBCF,

where the creators' use of commissive language can similarly enhance the credibility of their project, thereby reducing backers perceived risks. As noted in previous studies, the reduction of perceived risk is a critical component in the decision-making process of potential investors, particularly in high-stakes or uncertain environments (E. Mollick, 2014; Pennebaker et al., 1999). The application of commissive speech acts in RBCF extends beyond mere project descriptions; it permeates every aspect of the creator's communication, including the "About the Creator" section. By articulating commitments and intentions, creators can signal their dedication to potential backers, enhancing their credibility and trustworthiness. This is not merely a transfer of information but a performative act that actively shapes the backer's perception and willingness to engage with the project. Insights from the literature, including findings from sectors such as marketing and online commerce, underscore that such performative acts can lead to increased engagement and support by reinforcing the creator's commitment to delivering on promises (Aditria et al., 2021; Amaefula, 2022; Septianasari et al., 2021; F. Wang et al., 2023). Given these theoretical underpinnings and empirical evidence, it becomes clear that commissive speech acts are instrumental in fostering trust and reducing perceived uncertainty in crowdfunding campaigns. By explicitly committing to future actions and demonstrating accountability, creators can enhance their appeal and effectiveness. Thus, we propose the following hypothesis:

H1: The use of commissive speech acts on About the creator section is positively related to the likelihood of achieving funding goals in RBCF campaigns.

Moreover, research in strategic communication highlights the importance of conveying emotions and attitudes to create deeper connections with audiences. In the context of crowdfunding, the creator's biography plays a pivotal role in establishing trust and rapport with potential backers, making the way creators communicate just as important as the content itself (Gerber et al., 2012; Singer, 2023). Expressive speech acts, which include the expression of emotions, attitudes, and interpersonal states, are particularly potent in this regard. By revealing their personal feelings, challenges, and motivations, creators can humanize their campaigns, making them more relatable and engaging for backers (Adamska-Mieruszevska et al., 2021). Such emotional and attitudinal expressions not only convey authenticity but also align with the principles of the Speech Act Theory, which posits that communication is not merely about information exchange but also about performing actions that influence the listener's perception and behavior (Johnston, 2013). In the context of RBCF, expressive speech acts can effectively build a relational connection between creators and backers, enhancing the sense of community and shared purpose that is essential for campaign success. This aligns with findings from consumer behavior research, where emotional engagement and personal narratives have been shown to significantly increase consumer trust, loyalty, and, ultimately, financial commitment (Singer, 2023). By leveraging expressive speech acts, creators can foster a supportive environment, encouraging backers to feel emotionally invested in the project's success. Therefore, integrating expressive speech acts into the creator's biography can be a strategic tool for enhancing the perceived relatability and credibility of the creator, which in turn boosts the RBCF campaign's appeal and effectiveness. This deeper engagement through expressive communication forms a critical link between the creator and their audience. Thus, we propose the following hypothesis:

H2: The use of expressive speech acts on About the creator section is positively related to the likelihood of achieving funding goals in RBCF campaigns.

3.2. Visual credibility

In this research, we define visual branding in RBCF as the strategic application of visual elements by the creator to convey professionalism, trustworthiness, and personal validity. Unlike most other forms of campaign materials, visual branding emphasizes the creator's identity

and appearance, which are pivotal in shaping backers' initial impressions, as previously presented in Fig. 1. Prior research has acknowledged that consistency in visual branding can create a recognizable and trustworthy identity (Cialdini, 1993), influencing backer decisions (Belleflamme et al., 2014). Past research has demonstrated that well-crafted campaign pages and engaging multimedia content are crucial in building backer trust and increasing campaign success (Agrawal et al., 2015; Kuppuswamy & Bayus, 2018b). However, the impact of a creator's section visual quality remains unexplored. This is specifically important in RBCF, where the creator's reputation is central to building trust. Our study expands the literature by examining the photo used in the "About the Creator" section, specifically analyzing how its quality, and the use of a logo or entrepreneur's headshot image could influence backer trust and the likelihood of campaign success.

Marketing research indicates that logos serve as powerful nonverbal cues, conveying credibility by signaling expertise and trustworthiness, which in turn enhances consumers' trust and willingness to engage (Lowry et al., 2014). This effect is particularly important in the RBCF context, where the absence of physical interaction drives backers to rely heavily on visual cues to assess a project's legitimacy. A professionally designed logo can act as a "virtual storefront" and convey the professionalism and values of the fundraiser. Therefore, we propose:

H3: The use of a logo as the avatar on the About the Creator section is positively related to the likelihood of achieving funding goals in RBCF campaigns.

Moreover, image quality, explained by sharpness, brightness and contrast are positively associated with higher perceived competence and trustworthiness (Todorov et al., 2015). Studies on social media profiles suggest that high-contrast profile photos tend to be perceived as friendlier, more memorable, and more credible (Bakhshi et al., 2014). We expect a similar effect in the RBCF context. Therefore:

H4: The use of a high-quality avatar photo on the About the Creator section is positively related to the likelihood of achieving funding goals in RBCF campaigns.

3.3. Social engagement

Apart from verbal and visual cues, empirical evidence underscores the positive impact of creator engagement on campaign success. One-way communications like project FAQs and updates have been noted to boost backer confidence and participation, as such interactions may keep backers informed and signal that the creator is actively managing the project (Bernardino & Santos, 2020).

Moreover, projects where creators actively interact with backers tend to perform better in reaching funding goals. For instance, the higher number of comments and creator's responsiveness both in terms of length and speed of reply are positively related with fundraising success (N. Wang et al., 2018). In other words, campaigns where creators frequently and promptly reply to backer comments are more likely to achieve their funding targets. Similarly, a high reply rate by the creator can signal credibility and amplify the backer participation. Bringing these insights together, we argue that a creator's interactive engagement with backers is a strong signal of project reliability that builds trust and confidence, ultimately improving funding outcomes. When creators invest effort in answering questions, clarifying doubts, and acknowledging supporter input, backers are more likely to believe in the project's viability and spread the word, increasing the campaign's chances of success. Therefore, we propose the following hypothesis:

H5: Creator's engagement with potential backers, in the form of actively responding to potential backers' questions and comments is positively related to the likelihood of achieving funding goals in RBCF campaigns.

Besides, creator's past participation and experience with other projects serve as a strong indicator of their understanding of the crowdfunding ecosystem and their commitment to its community. This form of participation signals reciprocity and community orientation, traits that

potential backers value highly. Research shows that individuals who actively engage in a community are often perceived as more trustworthy and committed, significantly influencing investment decisions (Zheng et al., 2014). Additionally, creators who participate in other projects tend to develop better insights into successful campaign strategies, which they can apply when launching their own projects (Kuppuswamy & Bayus, 2018a). In RBCF, the research noted that a creator's previous engagement could signal their credibility and project management skills (E. Mollick, 2014). However, the work does not explore how this type of engagement, specifically backing other projects, can be further leveraged as a visual trust signal within the campaign environment itself. Active participation not only demonstrates the creator's involvement in the community but also helps build trust and reduce perceived risks among potential backers (Bandura & Cervone, 1986; Duan et al., 2020). In RBCF, the creator's community participation and experience are visually highlighted by a number in the About the Creator section. By exploring how visual elements that highlight creators past contributions to the crowdfunding ecosystem can enhance trust, we offer new insights into how these signals influence backer perceptions and RBCF campaign success. This approach aligns with social proof principles, where demonstrated commitment and involvement within the community positively influence others' willingness to support. By that, we propose the following Hypothesis:

H6: Creator's history of backing other projects, as displayed on their biography page, is positively associated with the likelihood of achieving funding goals in RBCF campaigns.

On the other side of the engagement spectrum, social media is a powerful tool for extending the reach of crowdfunding campaigns, enhancing transparency, and fostering trust among potential backers. The visibility of a creator's social networks can amplify the credibility of their crowdfunding efforts by demonstrating connectedness and influence, which are critical for building trust in online transactions (Agrawal et al., 2015; Colombo et al., 2015). Studies show that social media significantly impacts the diffusion of information about crowdfunding campaigns, leading to more backers and higher pledge amounts. This effect is primarily due to the perceived legitimacy and transparency that social media connections provide, thereby attracting more support for the campaign (Koch & Cheng, 2016; E. Mollick, 2014; E. R. Mollick, 2012).

In the context of this study, "integration of social media connections" refers specifically to the presence of a Facebook, Instagram or TikTok

connection in the "About the Creator" section of the crowdfunding campaign. This connection serves as a verified tag, allowing backers to easily identify and authenticate the creator's identity, particularly if they are already a fan or follower of the creator. While this may not directly drive campaign success through mere presence alone, it acts as an essential layer of social proof for potential backers who are looking to support a credible creator. A social media connection, even if passive, provides an opportunity for backers to verify and trust the creator's authenticity, especially when they have an established community or influence outside the platform (Agrawal et al., 2015; Koch & Cheng, 2016). However, research suggests that to maximize the benefits of social media connections, creators must go beyond just linking their profiles. Active engagement, such as regular updates, interactive content, and direct communication, has been shown to enhance campaign visibility and credibility further, leveraging existing networks and interactions to drive more significant backer trust and participation (Colombo et al., 2015; E. Mollick & Kuppuswamy, 2016). Therefore, while the mere presence of a social media connection may serve as a fundamental trust signal, its impact could be significantly amplified with more dynamic use. Given these insights, we propose the following hypothesis:

H7: Creator's social media integration, as displayed on their biography page, is positively related to the likelihood of achieving funding goals in RBCF campaigns.

Fig. 2 shows the conceptual model of our research.

4. Research methodology

4.1. Data collection

We developed a custom web scraper in Python to systematically collect data from Kickstarter, a leading RBCF platform that operates on an all-or-nothing (AON) funding model. The data that we collected was from 31 different subcategories including "Technology", "Art", and "Fashion" category projects, all characterized by different risk, reward format, and innovative intensities that have different success rates among them. Many of the projects with high innovation levels, showcased high-risk, high-reward scenario with lower than usual funding success but with the potential of attracting large sums when successful specifically in technology subcategories (Chaichi, 2021; Kickstarter, 2025; E. Mollick, 2014). Such uncertainty and potential for large payoffs

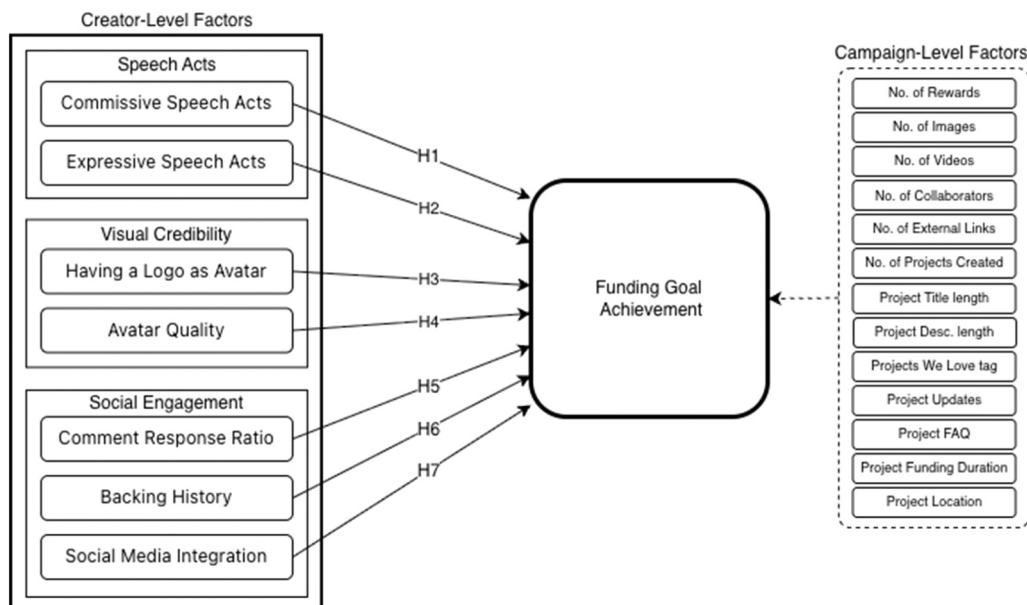


Fig. 2. Conceptual Model of the Study.

amplify the role of trust signals, making it an ideal context for examining how creators' self-presentation influences backer decision-making (Courtney et al., 2017; Hopp et al., 2022). The web scraper extracted data from 9907 campaigns launched between August 2009 and May 2025.

The preliminary data collection process comprised the collection of detailed RBCF campaign information, including the project title, description, number of images, videos, rewards, project goal, number of comments and FAQs, and the total amount of money raised. The scraper also extracted data from the "About the Creator" section, covering elements such as the creator's name, avatar, description, social media links, number of collaborators, and the count of projects they had backed and created. This dual methodology enabled us to compile a comprehensive dataset incorporating project and creator-level factors. We implemented a data-cleaning technique to guarantee the consistency and comparability of the financial data. Since our data included campaigns from 32 different countries of origin outside of the United States, a Python code was first utilized to detect and standardize currency symbols and for that all financial data were converted to U.S. Dollars to enable consistent comparison across several campaigns.

To maintain a clear focus on external funding dynamics, we calculated a metric called success ratio, which is divided by the total amount raised by the project's stated goal. A ratio greater than one indicates that the campaign met or exceeded its funding target, and on the other hand, campaigns that failed to reach their goal at varying degrees have a success ratio below 1. Although we have our analysis on every project that raised even a single U.S. dollar, we decided to exclude projects that raised zero funds (i.e., a success ratio of 0). These projects account for 7.6 % of our initial dataset, which sits around with previous findings that around 16.8 % of failed Kickstarter campaigns receive no funding at all, thus forming a distinct phenomenon in RBCF research. Previous research indicates that roughly 34 % of the first \$500 in crowdfunding comes from such friends-and-family backers, even though they ultimately contribute only about 22 % of the total funding on average (Borst et al., 2018; Y. Zhou et al., 2022). Zero-funded fundraising attempts typically lack external validation and rely predominantly on personal networks, making them qualitatively different phenomena from partially or fully funded projects (Agrawal et al., 2015; Troise et al., 2020). By omitting these cases, we concentrate on campaigns that garnered external support, providing a clearer view of how creator-level factors influence public crowdfunding success. This refinement yielded a final dataset of 9150 campaigns which was then prepared for further processing, including data preprocessing, grouping, and labeling, before being analyzed using LIWC techniques and subsequent regression analysis. Fig. 3 illustrates the steps taken to collect, process, and analyze

the data.

4.2. Variable overview and selection rationale

Table 1 provides a comprehensive list of all the independent variables, along with their operational definitions and descriptive statistics. The correlation matrix for all independent variables is provided in Appendix A.

4.2.1. Dependent variable

We model campaign performance as a continuous outcome rather than a binary success indicator. Our dependent variable is the campaign's funding ratio, defined as the total amount raised divided by the campaign's fundraising goal. We operationalize this variable as:

$$FundingRatio_i = \frac{FundsRaised_i}{FundingGoal_i} \quad (1)$$

Where FundsRaised_i is the total pledged amount at the close of the campaign *i*, and FundingGoal_i is the requested goal for the campaign *i*. The degree to which a project exceeds, meet, or falls short of its financial goal is captured by the nature of this variable, which presents a continuous measure of campaign success. Additionally, the potential ceiling effect which commonly occurs by using a binary variable, is now mitigated, helping to make a distinction between the highly successful campaigns and the ones that merely meet their fundraising targets (E. Mollick, 2014).

4.2.2. Independent variables

We incorporate a range of independent variables derived from the creators' biographical text on RBCF campaign pages (See layer 3 of Fig. 1), analyzed using LIWC technique (Pennebaker et al., 1999), in tandem with the Harvard University's General Inquirer, a dictionary merging the Harvard IV-4 and Lasswell lexicons into 182 distinct categories using a python code that we developed for it. LIWC is a dictionary-based textual analysis tool that scans each word in a document and assigns it to one or more predefined categories (e.g., positive emotion, negative emotion, personal pronouns, cognition) and scores them based on normalized frequency of them being used in a text which allows us to quantify the use of different speech acts, rooted in speech act theory (Austin & Warnock, 1962; Searle, 1969), to assess how the language used by creators can impact the success of their campaigns. The variables include both expressive and commissive speech acts. As explained before in the conceptual framework section, Commissive speech acts, express commitments or intentions, such as needs, goals, attempts, means, persistence, completion, and virtues are identified by

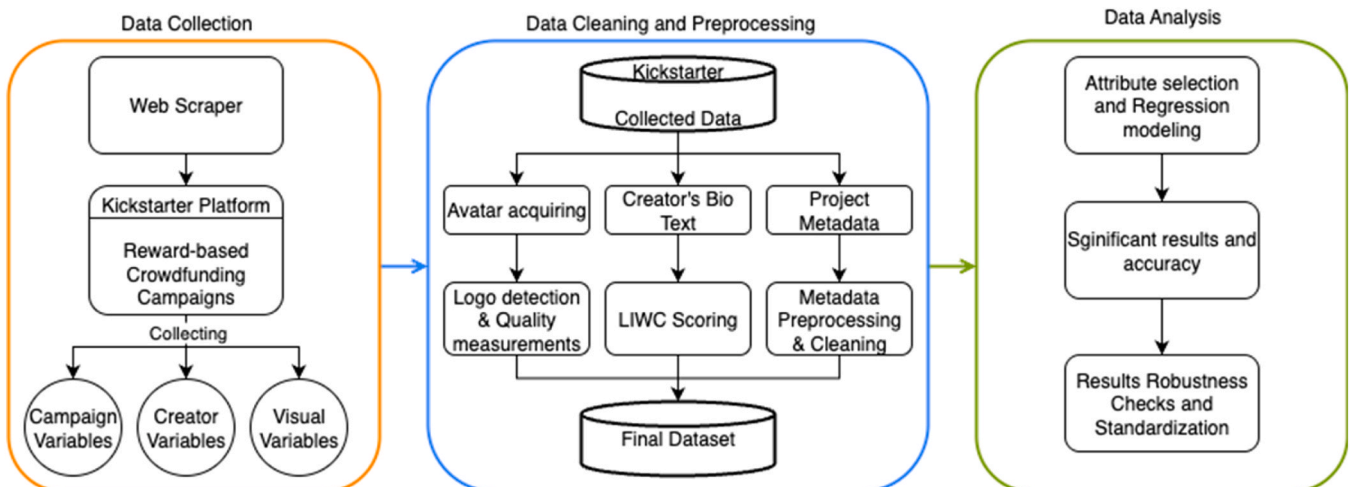


Fig. 3. Data Collection, Processing, and Analysis Flowchart.

Table 1
Descriptive Statistics and operationalization of variables.

Variable Type	Variables	Operationalization	Obs	Mean	Std.	Min	Max
Dependent	(1) Funding Ratio	Success Ratio of fundraising calculated by dividing the Funds gathered over the funding goal.	9907	3.469	14.470	0	638
	(2) Number of Rewards	Integer count of distinct reward options listed on the campaign page.	9907	6.932	5.29	0	77
	(3) Number of Collaborators	Integer count of collaborators listed on the About the creator section of the campaign.	9907	.257	.936	0	13
	(4) Number of Projects Created	Integer count of projects created by the creator.	9907	3.835	7.686	0	119
	(5) Number of Images	Integer count of images uploaded on the campaign page.	9907	10.299	13.255	0	188
	(6) Number of Videos	Integer count of videos uploaded on the campaign page.	9907	1.353	2.11	0	44
	(7) Funding Duration	Integer count of days from the campaign start date to the end date.	9907	32.677	12.73	0	91
	(8) Location	The geographical location of the campaign creator (0 = Outside North America, 1 = Inside North America)	9907	.72	.449	0	1
	(9) Project Title Length	Integer count of words in the campaign title.	9907	5.766	2.636	1	22
	(10) Project Description Length	Integer count of words in the campaign description.	9907	16.265	5.871	1	45
	(11) Number of External Links	Integer count of presence of external websites associated with the crowdfunding campaign.	9907	.312	.463	0	1
	(12) Projects We Love Tag	Whether the project has been tagged as “Projects We Love” by the Kickstarter platform (0 = No, 1 = Yes).	9907	.081	.273	0	1
	(13) Number of Updates	Integer count of updates posted on the project page.	9907	6.699	9.59	0	175
Campaign-level	(14) Number of FAQs	Integer count of FAQs posted on the project page.	9907	1.197	3.614	0	60
	(15) Comm. Speech Act Need	LIWC Score for the words or phrases related to needs and necessities	9907	.01	.019	0	.333
	(16) Comm. Speech Act Goal	LIWC Score for the words or phrases related to goals and targets.	9907	.003	.011	0	.333
	(17) Comm. Speech Act Try	LIWC Score for the words or phrases related to trying and attempting.	9907	.009	.021	0	.5
	(18) Comm. Speech Act Means	LIWC Score for the words or phrases related to means and methods.	9907	.029	.034	0	.4
	(19) Comm. Speech Act Persist	LIWC Score for the words or phrases related to persistence and perseverance.	9907	.003	.01	0	.333
	(20) Comm. Speech Act Complete	LIWC Score for the words or phrases related to completion and fulfilment.	9907	.011	.023	0	.333
	(21) Comm. Speech Act Virtue	LIWC Score for the words or phrases related to virtues and positive traits.	9907	.034	.043	0	1
	(22) Expr. Speech Act PosAff	LIWC Score for the words or phrases related to positive emotions and affect.	9907	.008	.021	0	.5
	(23) Expr. Speech Act NegAff	LIWC Score for the words or phrases related to negative emotions and affect.	9907	.001	.007	0	.167
	(24) Expr. Speech Act Self	LIWC Score for the self-referential words like “I” and “me.”	9907	.04	.052	0	.5
	(25) Expr. Speech Act Our	LIWC Score for the inclusive words like “we” and “our.”	9907	.012	.028	0	.4
	(26) Expr. Speech Act Intrj.	LIWC Score for the of interjections like “wow” and “hey.”	9907	.005	.013	0	.2
	(27) Expr. Speech Act Vice	LIWC Score for the words or phrases related to vices and negative traits.	9907	.006	.016	0	.4
	(28) Expr. Speech Act Feel	LIWC Score for the words or phrases related to feelings and emotions.	9907	0	.004	0	.25
	(29) Having a Logo	The presence of a professional logo in the project (0 = No logo, 1 = Logo present).	9907	.566	.496	0	1
	(30) Avatar Quality	The quality of creator’s avatars in the campaign if it has one (Score for the projects without an avatar is 0).	9907	0	1	−3.264	1.745
	(31) Number of Projects backed	Integer count of projects backed by the creator.	9907	14.39	56.232	0	1321
	(32) Creator Comment Response Ratio	Ratio of comments responded by creator to the total amount of comments received on a campaign page.	9907	.065	.158	0	1.5
Independent (Creator-level)	(33) Social Media Integration	The integration of social media connections, into the about the creator section of crowdfunding campaign (0 = No social media connection, 1 = social media connection present).	9907	.342	.475	0	1

future-oriented or obligation-related terms (e.g., “will,” “guarantee,” “ensure,” “attempt”). These variables reflect the promises or commitments made by creators regarding their campaigns. Meanwhile, Expressive speech acts reflect the creator’s emotions and attitudes, such as self-references (e.g., “I” and “me”), first-person plural pronouns (e.g., “we” and “our”), interjections (e.g., “wow” and “hey”), expressions of positive and negative affect (e.g., “yes” and “no”), and vice terms signifying moral disapproval or misfortune (e.g., “wrong,” “misery”). For instance, a creator stating, “*I promise to deliver on time and ensure top quality*” would show elevated Commissive scores, while phrases like, “*We’re thrilled about this idea*” or “*I’m so grateful for your support*” would register as more Expressive. This approach offers several advantages. First, it is scalable, enabling the automated analysis of thousands of campaign creator bios with minimal human intervention. Second, it provides robust, quantitative measures of language use, facilitating hypothesis testing about how different speech act categories influence backer perceptions. Finally, LIWC has been widely used in crowdfunding research to reveal how linguistic style and rhetorical cues can sway funding outcomes (Ansari & Gupta, 2021; Ghobadi, 2023; Kim et al., 2016; Mitra & Gilbert, 2014; Parhankangas & Renko, 2017).

Our assessment of visual credibility uses a Python/OpenCV pipeline that first classifies the creator’s avatar and then quantifies its quality. For classification, we implemented an improved two-pass face detector based on Haar cascades (Viola & Jones, 2001). Avatars are converted to grayscale, contrast-normalized, and scanned at multiple scales. A second pass with stricter parameters and a complementary profile-face cascade reduces false negatives. An image is labeled a headshot if either pass returns a valid face region, otherwise it is labeled a logo/mark. We audited a random subset to verify labeling reliability. To measure image quality consistently across headshots and logos, we extracted three luminance-based features for every avatar which are sharpness (edge clarity), brightness (average light level), and contrast (spread of light and dark). Because these cues are correlated, we summarized them into a single composite avatar quality index using principal component analysis (PCA). In practice, we standardize the three features, fit PCA on the full avatar set, and use the first component score as the index, then rescale it to have mean zero and unit variance. Higher values correspond to crisper, well-exposed, appropriately contrasted images; lower values reflect soft focus, dim/overbright exposure, or flat/harsh contrast. This design keeps the metric transparent and replicable while avoiding black-box aesthetics scoring. Prior work indicates that clarity and exposure shape first-impression judgments and credibility online, motivating these dimensions (S. Chen, Wang, et al., 2023; Guo et al., 2022; Todorov et al., 2015), and that human faces elicit greater engagement and trust than non-face imagery in social platforms and crowdfunding contexts (Bakhshi et al., 2014; Duan et al., 2020). Using the headshot/logo indicator together with the composite quality index allows us to separate what is shown from how well it is shown and to test visual-credibility effects in a consistent, replicable manner across the corpus.

We also explore the creator’s engagement and commitment to the RBCF ecosystem through multiple metrics. First, we record the number of projects previously backed by the creator, reflecting their broader involvement and social proof of reciprocity within the community. Second, we identify whether the creator’s profile is “Connected to Facebook,” indicating an external social media link that can amplify reach and credibility. This variable is indicated as a tag in the “About the creator” section (e.g., If connected appears as “Connected to Facebook”) of each project, and by clicking on it, the backer can access the creators’ Facebook page, which can be personal or branded towards the campaign’s idea and team. Note that we see this tag as a verified tag that is common these days on social media platforms, showcasing the legitimacy of the creator on its profile to help with backers’ trust in the project prior to investment. Beyond these established indicators, we introduce a

novel Creator Comment Response Ratio, the proportion of comments to which the creator directly replies. By scraping both the total comments on each campaign and the number of creator responses, this ratio provides a transparent, creator-level measure of active engagement. It isolates how diligently an entrepreneur addresses backer inquiries and fosters dialogue, thereby distinguishing creator responsiveness from other campaign-level dynamics. Through these combined measures, we offer a comprehensive view of how creators’ community interactions influence trust, engagement, and, ultimately, fundraising outcomes in RBCF.

4.2.3. Campaign-level factors check

The campaign-level factors are integral to our conceptual model, ensuring that the effects of our primary independent variables related to speech acts, visual branding, and social engagement are accurately assessed, providing a comprehensive understanding of the factors that drive RBCF success. For that, the number of rewards offered in a campaign is controlled (Belleflamme et al., 2014; Kuppuswamy & Bayus, 2018a) due to its impact on campaign attractiveness by catering to diverse backer preferences. Similarly, the number of collaborators is an essential control (Colombo et al., 2015; E. Mollick, 2014), as a larger team can enhance campaign credibility, influencing backer confidence positively. We also control for the number of projects previously created by the creator (Agrawal et al., 2015), as past successful crowdfunding experiences can enhance a creator’s reputation and reliability. Visual elements, such as the number of images and videos, are controlled (Koch & Cheng, 2016; E. Mollick, 2014) due to their critical role in engaging backers, as shown in studies that emphasize the importance of conveying the project’s quality and value through visual cues. The duration of the crowdfunding campaign is another important control (Gerber & Hui, 2013; E. Mollick, 2014), given its potential to influence campaign exposure and urgency. Additionally, the geographical location of the project creator as they are inside North America or outside of it is controlled (Burtch et al., 2013; Colombo et al., 2015), for addressing regional biases that can affect support levels. The length of the project title and description are included as controls (Gerber & Hui, 2013; Kuppuswamy & Bayus, 2018a), with previous studies emphasizing the importance of clear and detailed communication in effectively conveying the project’s objectives. The presence and number of external website associated with the project is controlled (Belleflamme et al., 2014), for its role in enhancing perceived professionalism, which fosters greater trust among potential backers (Koch & Cheng, 2016). Additionally, we account for the number of project FAQs and updates (Burtch et al., 2013; E. Mollick, 2014). Lastly, whether the project has been tagged as “Projects We Love” by Kickstarter is included in campaign-level factors, as this endorsement often boosts visibility and interest, likely increasing the chances of success.

4.3. Empirical models

We test how creator-level factors relate to reward-based crowdfunding performance beyond standard campaign-level factors by performing a 4-stage hierarchical regression analysis (Cramer, 2003). We estimate a sequence of hierarchical linear regression models in which we enter variables in theoretically motivated blocks and evaluate the incremental explanatory power of each block. After accounting for well-known campaign-level factors that prior research has associated with crowdfunding success, this approach enables us to evaluate whether creator-level factors provide significant predictive value (Borst et al., 2018; Colombo et al., 2015; E. Mollick, 2014). As recommended, this hierarchical approach was assessed by testing the change in R-square (R^2) from one stage (model) to the next. Following established practice in crowdfunding research, where funding outcomes and financial ratios are often highly skewed, we perform a log

transformation of the dependent variable to stabilize variance, address heteroscedasticity, and support linear regression assumptions (Burch et al., 2013; Colombo et al., 2015; Koch & Cheng, 2016; E. Mollick, 2014). We apply a log10-transformation as following:

$$DV_i = \log_{10}\left(\frac{FundsRaised_i}{FundingGoal_i}\right) \quad (2)$$

The log10-transformation's distribution is closer to symmetric which improves homoscedasticity and approximate normality of residuals that are important for inference in ordinary least squares (OLS) regression. Before applying the log10-transformation, the 757 cases without any amount of funds raised were dropped from the dataset. The log transformed DV's mean is negative because of the high failure rate of campaigns over the Kickstarter platform. Indeed, the campaigns that did not meet their stated goal show a negative DV value. This observation is in line with what the platform reports as the cumulative fundraising success rate of projects on Kickstarter is around 42 % (Kickstarter, 2025).

The first model (baseline model) includes all known campaign-level factors reported by previous research. Each variable's statistical significance was evaluated by using stepwise regression methods, which includes testing coefficients, t-values, and p-values to identify their relevance to the model. The results of this model provide the baseline to evaluate if and how much the proposed creator-level factors introduced in Models 2–5 improve the explanation of the success of Kickstarter campaigns.

$$DV_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 Rewards_i + \beta_2 Collaborators_i + \beta_3 ProjectsCreated_i + \beta_4 Images_i + \beta_5 Duration_i + \beta_6 TitleLength_i + \beta_7 DescriptionLength_i + \beta_8 ExternalLinks_i + \beta_9 PWLTag_i + \beta_{10} Updates_i + \beta_{11} FAQs_i + \varepsilon_i (, Baseline Model) \quad (3)$$

The second model adds the proposed speech-acts factors, namely commissive and expressive, which represent the level of commitment to the project and trustworthiness the creator can convey and create through verbal communication.

$$DV_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 Rewards_i + \beta_2 Collaborators_i + \beta_3 ProjectsCreated_i$$

$$+ \beta_4 Images_i + \beta_5 Duration_i + \beta_6 TitleLength_i + \beta_7 DescriptionLength_i + \beta_8 ExternalLinks_i + \beta_9 PWLTag_i + \beta_{10} Updates_i + \beta_{11} FAQs_i + \sum_j \beta_j^{(S)} SpeechAct_{ij} + \varepsilon_i (, Speech Acts Model) \quad (4)$$

The third model includes the visual credibility cues drawn from the creator's avatar in the "About the Creator" section, namely an indicator for using a logo instead of a headshot and a composed quality calculated score that captures overall avatar quality.

$$DV_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 Rewards_i + \beta_2 Collaborators_i + \beta_3 ProjectsCreated_i + \beta_4 Images_i + \beta_5 Duration_i + \beta_6 TitleLength_i + \beta_7 DescriptionLength_i + \beta_8 ExternalLinks_i + \beta_9 PWLTag_i + \beta_{10} Updates_i + \beta_{11} FAQs_i + \beta_{12}^{(V)} Logo_i + \beta_{13}^{(V)} AvatarQuality_i + \varepsilon_i (, Visual Credibility Model) \quad (5)$$

The fourth model includes the community engagement factors captured on the platform, including the Creator Comment Response Ratio, the number of projects the creator has backed, and an indicator for social media integration in the "About the Creator" section.

$$DV_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 Rewards_i + \beta_2 Collaborators_i + \beta_3 ProjectsCreated_i + \beta_4 Images_i + \beta_5 Duration_i + \beta_6 TitleLength_i + \beta_7 DescriptionLength_i + \beta_8 ExternalLinks_i + \beta_9 PWLTag_i + \beta_{10} Updates_i + \beta_{11} FAQs_i + \beta_{12}^{(E)} CommentResponseRatio_i + \beta_{13}^{(E)} ProjectsBacked_i + \beta_{14}^{(E)} SocialMediaIntegration_i + \varepsilon_i (, Social Engagement Model) \quad (6)$$

Finally, the fifth model includes all the proposed creator-level factors from the speech acts, visual credibility, and social engagement blocks as shown in Fig. 2.

$$DV_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 Rewards_i + \beta_2 Collaborators_i + \beta_3 ProjectsCreated_i + \beta_4 Images_i + \beta_5 Duration_i + \beta_6 TitleLength_i + \beta_7 DescriptionLength_i + \beta_8 ExternalLinks_i + \beta_9 PWLTag_i$$

Table 2
Empirical results of the main effects.

DV = $\log_{10}(\text{Campaign Funding Ratio})$	Baseline model (Campaign-level factors only)	Speech Acts model (H1 and H2)	Visual Credibility model (H3 and H4)	Social Engagement model (H5, H6 and H7)	Full Model (Creator-level + Campaign-level factors)
Comm. Speech Act Need	—	−4.929*** (0.65)	—	—	−4.620*** (0.64)
Comm. Speech Act Goal	—	−0.871 (1.05)	—	—	—
Comm. Speech Act Try	—	−0.582 (0.57)	—	—	—
Comm. Speech Act Means	—	−0.753* (0.39)	—	—	−0.893*** (0.34)
Comm. Speech Act Persist	—	−2.109* (1.13)	—	—	−2.242** (1.12)
Comm. Speech Act Complete	—	−0.917 (0.59)	—	—	—
Comm. Speech Act Virtue	—	0.286 (0.29)	—	—	—
Expr. Speech Act PosAff	—	−0.133 (0.57)	—	—	—
Expr. Speech Act NegAff	—	4.999*** (1.66)	—	—	4.314*** (1.59)
Expr. Speech Act Self	—	1.462*** (0.25)	—	—	1.235*** (0.24)
Expr. Speech Act Our	—	2.172*** (0.44)	—	—	2.035*** (0.43)
Expr. Speech Act Intrj.	—	−5.021*** (0.92)	—	—	−4.642*** (0.89)
Expr. Speech Act Vice	—	0.199 (0.72)	—	—	—
Expr. Speech Act Feel	—	−2.905 (2.57)	—	—	—
Having a Logo	—	—	−0.640*** (0.02)	—	−0.052*** (0.02)
Avatar Quality	—	—	0.048*** (0.01)	—	0.043*** (0.01)
Number of Projects backed	—	—	—	0.001*** (0.00)	0.001*** (0.00)
Creator Comment Response Ratio	—	—	—	1.069*** (0.08)	1.011*** (0.08)
Social Media Integration	—	—	—	0.016 (0.02)	—
Campaign-level factors included?	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Constant	−0.147***	−0.179***	−0.130***	−0.288***	−0.285***
Observation	9150	9150	9150	9150	9150
F-test	277.230***	326.212***	611.522***	593.448***	389.340***
Adjusted R-squared	0.463	0.471	0.465	0.476	0.483
Hypothesis ?	—	H1: ×, H2: ✓	H3: ×, H4: ✓	H5: ✓, H6: ✓, H7: ×	—

See Appendix C for the full regression results, Standard errors in parentheses; *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$

$$\begin{aligned}
& + \beta_{10} \text{Updates}_i + \beta_{11} \text{FAQs}_i + \sum_{j \in \text{Speech Acts}^*} \beta_j^{(S)} \text{SpeechAct}_{ij} \\
& + \beta_{12}^{(V)} \text{Logo}_i + \beta_{13}^{(V)} \text{AvatarQuality}_i \\
& + \beta_{14}^{(E)} \text{CommentResponseRatio}_i + \beta_{15}^{(E)} \text{ProjectsBacked}_i \\
& + \varepsilon_i, \text{ (Full Model)}
\end{aligned} \quad (7)$$

5. Empirical Analysis and Results

5.1. Results

Table 2 displays the empirical results of the primary effects of the tested variables. Each column represents a regression model that progressively integrates several variables to evaluate their influence on the dependent variable of funding ratio, which is the log10-transformed ratio of funding gathered over the goal. The baseline model, including all campaign-level factors, yielded an adjusted R^2 value of 0.463, indicating a moderate level of explanatory power attributable solely to these campaign-level factors. We retained variables that exhibited statistical significance, such as the number of rewards, the number of collaborators, the number of projects created, the number of images, funding duration, project title and description length, number of external links, the ‘Projects We Love’ tag, number of updates, and number of FAQs which demonstrated substantial predictive power. Baseline factors that demonstrated no significant effects, namely the location and number of videos, were eliminated to enhance model accuracy. Perhaps, past research found contradictory results about the effect of the number of videos on the DV. Indeed, previous studies show that while having an initial video is powerful, adding more videos eventually becomes counterproductive due to cognitive overload (Yang et al., 2020). This refinement process not only improved the model’s adjusted R^2 but also enhanced the overall fit, allowing a more precise examination of the roles played by expressive and commissive speech acts, quality avatars, and creator social engagement. Detailed information on the baseline model variable assessment, including coefficients, standard errors, t-values, and p-values for both the initial and refined models, is available in Appendix B. For readability, in the main text we focus on the substantive direction and significance of the key creator-level factors, and we report the full regression outputs for all hierarchical models in Appendix C.

In the Speech Acts model, the speech acts specification improves fit over the baseline model (adjusted $R^2 = 0.471$), indicating that the way creators compose the “Bio/About the Creator” text relates to funding outcomes. H2 is supported, whereas H1 is not supported because the significant commissive terms move in the opposite direction to the hypothesized positive effect. Within commissive, wording that focuses on means (procedural or operational phrasing such as “budget,” “implementation,” or “integration”) is associated with lower performance, and persistence language (e.g., “maintain,” “persevere,” “persist”) is likewise negative. Overt need framing (“need,” “lack,” “want,” “wish”) does not

operate as a positive lever in this context and is not associated with improved outcomes. Turning to expressive, matter-of-fact negative affect (e.g., “difficult,” “risk,” “problem”) is positively related, and both self-reference (“I,” “me,” “my”) and first-person plural (“we,” “our,” “us”) are positively related, consistent with bios that convey ownership and shared effort. By contrast, interjections with casual fillers such as “okay,” “well,” “yeah,” or “ugh”, are negatively related. We retain the significant commissive and expressive terms in the final model to capture these observed relationships, while noting the directional mismatch for H1.

The visual credibility model improves fit relative to the baseline with an adjusted R^2 of 0.465, which indicates that creator avatars are meaningfully related to funding outcomes. Avatar quality is positively associated with performance, consistent with clearer and better exposed portraits aligning with stronger results, therefore H4 is supported. Using a logo as the avatar is negatively associated with performance, which runs counter to the directional prediction in H3, hence H3 is not supported. In practice this pattern suggests that replacing a face headshot image with a brand mark may reduce the interpersonal cues that are helpful on reward-based crowdfunding platforms. Because both variables are statistically important and improve explanatory power, we retain them in the final specification while noting the directional mismatch for H3.

The social engagement model fit improves relative to the baseline model, with an adjusted R^2 of 0.476, indicating that engagement features meaningfully relate to outcomes. The Creator Comment Response Ratio is positively associated with funding performance, consistent with campaigns where creators address questions and clarify issues more often achieving stronger results. This finding supports H5. The number of projects backed is also positively associated with performance, which supports H6 and aligns with the view that creators who have participated as backers bring familiarity with platform norms and practices that benefit their own campaigns. Social media integration shows no reliable association with our dependent variable, so H7 is not supported.

The final model provides the best fit in our study (adjusted $R^2 = 0.483$), indicating that creator-authored language, the quality/type of the avatar image, and on-platform engagement collectively account for meaningful variation in campaign performance beyond formerly studied campaign-level factors. Coefficients estimated in the block models remain robust when entered together, with expected shifts in magnitude after mutual adjustment. Consistent with our hypothesis tests across models, expressive language, avatar quality, and platform engagement retain positive associations in the integrated setting (supporting H2, H4, H5, and H6), whereas the directional predictions for commissive language and logo usage are not supported (H1 and H3), and social-media integration does not receive support (H7) and is therefore excluded.

We next compare model fit across the hierarchical specifications to show the incremental contribution of each block of predictors. Table 3 showcases adjusted R^2 changes, changes in adjusted R^2 relative to the baseline campaign-level factors model, Root Mean Square Error (RootMSE) and overall F-statistics of each model. The increase in

Table 3
Goodness-of-fit and regression model comparison.

Models	Adjusted R-squared	Δ	RootMSE	F-test	Observation
Baseline (Campaign-level Factors)	0.463	-	1.107	277.230***	9150
Speech Acts	0.471	0.008	1.099	326.212***	9150
Visual Credibility	0.465	0.002	1.105	611.522***	9150
Social Engagement	0.476	0.013	1.094	593.488***	9150
Full (Campaign-level + Creator-level Factors)	0.483	0.020	1.086	389.340***	9150

*** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$

Table 4
Results of alternative models.

DV = $\log_{10}(\text{Campaign Funding Ratio})$	(A) Preferred Model	(B) Robust Errors	(C) Standardized
Comm. Speech Act Need	−4.620*** (0.64)	−4.620*** (0.69)	−0.088*** (0.01)
Comm. Speech Act Means	−0.893*** (0.34)	−0.893*** (0.35)	−0.031*** (0.01)
Comm. Speech Act Persist	−2.242** (1.12)	−2.242** (1.26)	−0.023** (0.01)
Expr. Speech Act NegAff	4.314*** (1.59)	4.314*** (1.11)	0.030*** (0.01)
Expr. Speech Act Self	1.235*** (0.24)	1.235*** (0.24)	0.065*** (0.01)
Expr. Speech Act Our	2.035*** (0.43)	2.035*** (0.37)	0.057*** (0.01)
Expr. Speech Act Intrj.	−4.642*** (0.89)	−4.642*** (0.94)	−0.060*** (0.01)
Having a Logo	−0.052*** (0.02)	−0.052*** (0.02)	−0.052*** (0.02)
Avatar Quality	0.043*** (0.01)	0.043*** (0.01)	0.043*** (0.01)
Number of Projects backed	0.001*** (0.00)	0.001*** (0.00)	0.036*** (0.01)
Creator Comment Response Ratio	1.011*** (0.08)	1.011*** (0.05)	0.016*** (0.01)
Campaign-level factors included?	✓	✓	✓
Constant	−0.285***	−0.285***	−0.626***
Observation	9150	9150	9150
F-test	389.340***	392.245***	389.340***
Adjusted R-squared	0.483	0.484	0.483

All the variables except dependent and Binary variables have been standardized in the results indicated in the column (C).
Standard errors in parentheses; *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$

explanatory power when we add speech acts, visual credibility, and engagement factors shows that creator-level factors account for additional variance in funding outcomes beyond campaign-level factors.

As shown in Table 3, the full model, which combines speech acts, visual credibility, and social engagement with campaign-level factors, attains the highest adjusted R^2 (0.483) in our data, indicating that creator-level factors materially improve explanatory power over a campaign-only baseline. We retain all statistically significant creator-level terms, irrespective of sign, to capture the observed relationships. Detailed interpretation is deferred to the Discussion section.

5.2. Robustness

To ensure the robustness of our results, we conducted several additional checks. Variance inflation factors (VIFs) were calculated to assess the potential multicollinearity among the predictors. As shown in Appendix D, all VIF values are well below the common threshold of 10, with the highest VIF value of 1.372 and mean VIF of 1.152. Therefore, we concluded that multicollinearity is not a concern in our models. To ensure the robustness of our findings, we conducted additional analyses, presented in Table 4.

Column B re-estimates the preferred specification using heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors. Signs and significance remain unchanged, which reduces concern about heteroskedasticity in our complementary robustness check. Column C standardizes all continuous predictors, allowing effect sizes to be compared on a common scale. The largest absolute effect among continuous variables is the negative coefficient for Need. Among positive predictors, Self and Our are the most pronounced, followed by Avatar Quality and the number of projects backed. Negative Affect speech acts remain positive with a smaller magnitude. Interjections speech acts continue to show a sizable negative association, with Means and Persist also negative but more modest. The logo indicator remains negative, and since it is binary, its coefficient is not directly comparable to the standardized effects. Across columns A through C, the pattern of signs and statistical significance matches the preferred model, and adjusted R^2 values are essentially identical, indicating that our main findings are stable under these robustness checks.

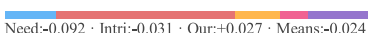
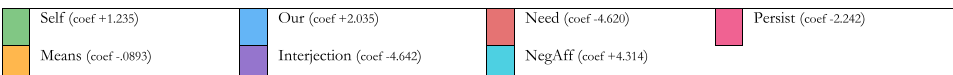
6. Discussions and implications

6.1. Discussion

The overarching research question guiding this study focuses on the role of the entrepreneur human capital in the decision of investors supporting the project on crowdfunding platforms. Several disciplines, such as marketing, social psychology, and digital communication, have already found significant relationships between creator level factors and project success. In this study, we explore the relationship between elements in Kickstarter projects that reflect creator-specific information and campaign success, measured with the fundraising outcome. We identify three main elements of creator-level factor, namely the profile image, the textual self-introduction (“About the Creator”), and the social engagement. The results show that creators’ biography do significantly affect fundraising outcomes. The two aspects of the textual self-introduction, commissive and expressive, are significantly related to the fundraising outcome, but with a different direction. Contrary to the expectations, commissive speech acts, which express commitments or intentions related to the project, are negatively related to the fundraising outcome. This result can be explained with the findings of recent studies suggesting that commitment is a multidimensional concept, with each dimension having a positive or negative effect on entrepreneurial outcome (Gabay-Mariani et al., 2024). These dimensions can be classified under two primary bases of commitment, instrumental and affective. The former refers to a broader sense of material exchange and costs, while the latter refers to an emotional bond between the creator and the project (Gabay-Mariani, 2022). Since our definition of commitment overlaps the instrumental commitment base, the findings show that merely committing to a material exchange does not increase the likelihood of success but, in general, is associated with lower funding outcomes.

On the other hand, expressive speech acts overlap with the definition of affective commitment, which our results show is, in general, significantly related to funding outcomes. This expressive layer reflects how creators express their emotions and attitudes within the “About the Creator” section. The information is particularly important for backers’ decision-making as it helps to evaluate the genuineness and relatability

Table 5
Examples of Creator Bios with High and Low Speech acts based on our analysis results.

Bios with High Speech Acts	Bios with Low Speech Acts
Chicken Transition Oracle Deck by The Empathetic Chicken · Score +0.113 Score Breakdown:  Our:+0.106 · Self:+0.099 · Intrj:-0.093 · NegAff:+0.069 Hello! My name is Shauni & I'm just a fellow being finding my way & healing through art, meaning & magic. When I was growing up, art was vital. It gave me an outlet & a focus outside of the chaos I knew as home. It allowed me to create a connection to myself & express what was important to me when there was no one there to see or hear me. Art helped me access a sense of home within. When everything around me felt hopeless & overwhelming, all I had to turn to was my imagination. Recognizing this ability & establishing that foundation within has continued to assist me throughout my entire life. I believe we all have the capacity to heal & process our adverse experiences through art & other ways of coming home to ourselves. We can establish our own sense of comfort & belonging when it's not guaranteed elsewhere. We can refocus our attention & use our imagination as an act of resistance against the harmful effects of misguided authority. We can use it as a form of reclamation of the freedom over our minds. No one can ever truly take that from us if we understand & remember our full power. I'm here to remind you of that. In the words of one of my favorite bands, "Art is the weapon. Your imagination is the ammunition. Stay dirty & stay dangerous. Create & Destroy as you see fit." -My Chemical Romance Thank you so much for being here! <3 Find me on Instagram and YouTube.	Lucky Dog Pets Vending Machines by Emma · Score -0.010 Score Breakdown:  Self:+0.066 · Need:-0.033 · Persist:-0.024 · Intrj:-0.017 Hello everyone! I'm pleased to introduce Lucky Dog Pet Sitting, the go to pet care in Estes Park! I'm Emma Marshall, owner/caretaker. A love for animals was instilled in me young, growing up my grandma owned a pet store and I came home with a new pet after just about every trip. I'm excited and ready to provide the best pet care in the Estes Valley! Dog sitting, farm sitting, drop in care and everything in between I'm your girl! I'm ready to snuggle all your sweet babies. Since making Lucky Dog Pet Sitting official in November 2021 I have been booked and busy. I am so grateful to the Estes Park Community and visiting guest for trusting me with your furry best friends. I'm excited to go into our first summer season with all of the of the knowledge I have learned through my first year in business. Lucky Dog Pet Sitting is named after my childhood dog, Lucky. Lucky was a Border Collie mix that was amazing at catching a frisbee, had the best food dance, and liked to dig in his water bowl to find the perfect drink. He hated feet but loved to cuddle and scratches behind his ears. Lucky had the absolute best life living out his final years laying in the front yard of his mountain home in Pinewood Springs. He lived to be 18 years old and crossed over the rainbow bridge in April 2018. Losing sweet Lucky Dog was a very hard thing to go through for Emma's family but his legacy lives on everyday though all the dogs of Lucky Dog Pet Sitting.
Large capacity compressible dry and wet separation backpack by Darlene Bags Shop · score +0.157 Score Breakdown:  Our:+0.199 · Need:-0.056 · NegAff:+0.053 · Persist:-0.027 We are a relatively new team, and we established this team because of the epidemic. We can guarantee our professionalism and our team has been working together for a while. From the design to the production of this backpack, each of us participated. After many discussions and revisions, this backpack can be said to appear in a "perfect" posture. It is also our expectation for the future. We hope that bad things can pass and that anyone can play around the world.	Enchanted Potions - Enamel Pins, Washi Tape and More! by Dakota Capranica · score -0.004 Score Breakdown:  Self:+0.162 · Intrj:-0.111 · Need:-0.055 · NegAff:+0.051 I'm an artist with a passion for all things that stick, pin, or sit wondrously for the world to see. As a cancer patient, I realized I needed to stop waiting for my chance to do what I want, and seize that chance for myself. My art and my work is my true steps towards what I've always wanted to do. I love all things nerd and pop culture, but my true passion is fantasy, particularly tabletop games like Dungeons and Dragons!
Dempsey Tamara by Siegfried Dempsey Tamara · Score +0.160 Score Breakdown:  Self:+0.128 · NegAff:+0.064 · Need:-0.034 · Our:+0.015 I run my own CrossFit box out of a small town close to Amsterdam. We have 150+ members who are all great people and are all passionate about their health and fitness. I turned 30 this summer, and it wasn't nearly as bad as I feared. I enjoy training and competing in CrossFit. I live together with my girlfriend in a small apartment close to the box and walking or riding my bike to the gym are one of my favorite things to do (except when it rains). Before I started CrossFit in April 2012 (doing Fran at 60 kg's instead of 42.5 because I read the WOD wrong), I competed in bobsleigh, and before that in american football, with my 2 years of college football being the highlight of my career.	Captain Dan Payne by Dan Payne · Score -0.135 Score Breakdown:  Need:-0.092 · Intrj:-0.031 · Our:+0.027 · Means:-0.024 Captain Dan comes from a long line of captains. His father and grandfather were captains. Dan has been on a boat since he was a kid. He's passion in life is everything to do with boats and being captain. Captain Dan Payne has had the Allison E. for over 17 Yrs, sold it and then bought it back a couple years later. The Allison E. is a Stevens Brothers Boat. The last boat delivered by Steven's Brothers before the outbreak of World War II. This boat has no sister ships. THE ONLY ONE IN THE WORLD!! It is Captain Dan's mission in life to save her and give back. The previous owner's between Dan tried to preserve her but one rule in boating is it has to be used regularly and need tons of TLC. So, come on our adventure and help us save this beauty.
Legend 	

$$\text{Score} = (1.235 \times \text{Expr. Self}) + (2.035 \times \text{Expr. Our}) - (4.620 \times \text{Comm. Need}) - (0.893 \times \text{Comm. Means}) - (2.242 \times \text{Comm. Persist}) - (4.642 \times \text{Expr. Intrj}) + (4.314 \times \text{Expr. NegAff})$$

of the campaign team since it usually features creators' bios or team introductions. Expressive elements like negative affect, for instance, candidly stating challenges such as "We've encountered supply chain issues", that is, expressing obstacles or challenges, positively affected the RBCF funding outcomes, which showing that openness about difficulties can elicit empathy, enhance authenticity, and galvanize support, improving the campaign's perceived authenticity (Small & Verrochi, 2009). This finding aligns with former studies that expressing negative effects can humanize the campaign, making the creator more relatable and trustworthy and creating a sense of urgency that compels action (Defazio et al., 2021). Either self-centered expressive and inclusive language (e.g., "I work hard" or "Our team works hard to solve this problem") positively influence fundraising outcomes, reinforcing the value of creating a collective identity that aligns with social identity theory, which posits that inclusive language fosters belonging and collective support (Thies et al., 2016). The negative impact of interjections (e.g., "Wow, this is so cool!") suggests that while they may convey enthusiasm, they can undermine the campaign's professionalism, detracting from its credibility (Bi et al., 2017). Our findings highlight that how creators express emotions with potential backers significantly impacts perceptions of credibility and trustworthiness. By balancing authenticity, empathy, and emotional commitment with a professional tone, creators can more effectively engage potential backers, even in high-uncertainty crowdfunding contexts. To give readers a better understanding of our findings, we have provided a few samples from the projects and creators with high and low speech acts effects based on our findings, in Table 5. To make these patterns concrete, we computed a single speech acts score for every biography. For each bio, we counted seven cues from our Harvard LIWC dictionary (Self, Our, NegAff, Need, Means, Persist, Interjections), normalized them for length, and combined them using the weights and directions from our preferred model. The "score breakdown" under each example in Table 5 shows how each cue contributed to the bio's total.

As Table 5 illustrates, the high-scoring bios read as anchored, inclusive, and candid. They foreground personal ownership ("I," "me," "my") and a shared identity with backers ("we," "our"), which creates social presence without sounding self-absorbed. When they mention difficulties, the tone is brief and matter-of-fact rather than dramatic. That small dose of grounded candor makes the creator feel transparent and competent. These bios also keep the focus on purpose and outcomes, which is what the creator is building, why it matters, and how the community fits in, rather than on the mechanics of doing the work. On the other hand, the low-scoring bios lean into a different mix. They rely heavily on need-centric phrasing ("we need," "we lack," "we want") and perseverance language ("we'll keep trying"), which shifts attention from value to scarcity and effort. They spend more words on process and logistics, which reads like operational overhead in a short biography. Casual interjections and filler make the tone chattier and less professional, diluting credibility. Even when these bios express enthusiasm, the overall message feels reactive, asking for help, promising to push through, or narrating hurdles, rather than proactive about capability and contribution.

To further showcase our point and findings based on our data and results, we ranked all projects by this speech acts score and compared the top 100 and bottom 100. Projects with high-scoring bios achieved a mean funding ratio of 3.55 (median 1.84) and an 80 % success rate (ratio > 1). Projects with low-scoring bios averaged 1.08 (median 1.00) with a 50 % success rate. The difference implies a $2.29 \times$ lift in average funding ratio and a + 30 %age-point increase in success probability for the high-scoring group. These are descriptive comparisons, not causal

estimates, but they align tightly with our model-based results and show, in practical terms, how small, text-level choices in the creator bio aggregate into meaningful differences in fundraising outcomes.

Another significant result is that visual branding, particularly the presence and quality of a professional picture on the creator's avatar, affects the funding outcome. Our analysis, bolstered by composite image quality scores, demonstrates that using not just any avatar, but a well-executed one with balanced composition and color harmony, is proved to greatly boost impressions of professionalism and credibility, which is in line with studies previously in publication showing the role that visual aspects play in building confidence and drawing backers (Gerber et al., 2012). For example, in highly innovative category of RBCF like technology campaigns where direct interaction with the product is typically limited or delayed until the product development phase is complete, such visual indicators become vital heuristics of trustworthiness and preparedness (Courtney et al., 2017). More importantly, a picture is significantly better than a logo in relation to the project funding outcomes. The preference for a picture can be explained by the fact that it helps diminishing the feelings of uncertainty and promotes trust (Broeder & Remers, 2018) between backers and creators (Steinbrück et al., 2002). In other social situations, such as remote work, the negative consequences of the digital separation between coworkers, are commonly overcome by re-embedding strategies, such as introducing face-to-face meetings in an otherwise distant relationship (Giddens, 1985; Riegelsberger & Angela Sasse, 2001). Re-embedding, in our case, is a strategy to provide meta-communicative features that are crucial for interpersonal interactions. In an in-person interaction, social cues from eye contact and gestures are crucial to establish trust. In an online interaction, the display of a personal photograph replaces such social cues providing support to establish trust between the two interacting subjects (Steinbrück et al., 2002).

A third dimension of our study was to look at the involvement of creators within the RBCF community, encompassing both the number of previously backed projects and the creator comment response ratio and how it might affect fundraising outcomes. Our findings confirm that these variables are strong predictors of RBCF success, aligning with the social capital theory, which posits that active involvement in community fosters trust and resource exchange (Burt, 2000). The active contribution of creators to other projects within the RBCF platform and promptly reply to backer questions or concerns help them to be seen as more devoted and ingrained in the community, which helps build confidence and reciprocity from possible backers. On the other hand, merely linking a social media account did not significantly predict funding outcomes, suggesting that a passive social media presence is insufficient for driving robust engagement. Studies indicate that creators who actively engage with their audience and build strong communities on social media platforms prior to launching their campaigns are more likely to achieve their funding goals (Kuppuswamy & Bayus, 2018a; Zheng et al., 2014). Social media stars and influencers who enter crowdfunding with an established and loyal following have a distinct advantage, as their pre-existing community support significantly boosts campaign visibility and trustworthiness (Lee & Hong, 2016; E. Mollick & Kuppuswamy, 2016). We suspect that a passive social media connection to the creators' bio functions primarily as a verification tag, signaling authenticity and legitimacy rather than actively driving backer engagement. This feature may help potential backers confirm they are backing the correct influencer or team, ensuring they invest in campaigns aligned with their pre-existing loyalties and interests.

6.2. Contributions

This study shifts the focus from campaigns to creators and advances a unified Creator-Level Factors perspective for digital marketplaces. Some of the results are theoretically non-obvious. First, in high-uncertainty crowdfunding, pragmatics beats sentiment. Expressive acts tied to social presence and shared identity relate positively to outcomes, while several commissive framings relate negatively, even though classic work would predict “more commitment results in more trust.” This asymmetry refines how IS research treats “commitment” online by separating affective from instrumental commitment in practice (Austin & Warnock, 1962; Gabay-Mariani, 2022; Searle, 1969). Second, we extend visual-identity theory by showing that a human face outperforms a logo and that image quality itself carries informational value for credibility, counter to the intuition that professional branding should dominate (Lowry et al., 2014; Mahmood et al., 2019; Todorov et al., 2015). Third, we connect platform-native social engagement to performance using observable traces, grounding social-capital mechanisms (Burt, 2000; Zheng et al., 2014) in measurable creator behaviors. Together, these contributions position the creator bio and avatar as a socio-technical interface where linguistic, visual, and relational cues jointly shape investor judgments, robust across heterogeneous project types and innovation intensities.

Beyond its theoretical insights, we introduce a creator-centric measurement toolkit that is scalable, transparent, and replicable across categories and time. It operationalizes speech acts in creator bios with curated dictionaries and a length-normalized weighted speech-acts score tied to the fitted model; quantifies avatar credibility by automatically distinguishing headshot photo vs. logo and scoring avatar quality with a composite image metric; and captures interactive engagement using native platform traces. Applied to a large, 16-year corpus with thousands of projects, the pipeline supports joint multimodal modeling that make effect patterns economically interpretable rather than merely significant.

For entrepreneurs, our findings translate into concrete guidance for them and the ecosystem. Creators can audit their bios with the speech acts, pair it with a high-quality headshot, and maintain visible “reply” behavior and community participation. The economic salience is non-trivial. In our top-bottom comparison, high-scoring bios are associated with materially higher funding ratios and success rates. The relevance is also reflected in recent platform design. Kickstarter has elevated entrepreneur presentation with a dedicated Creator tab, underscoring that creator-level indicators deserve first-class treatment on platform. Building on this, we are developing a creator assistance tool that surfaces strengths and gaps in bios and avatars (using our score and image checks, on top of the formerly studied campaign level indicators) and offers revisions and scoring suggestions aligned with the evidence, so campaign creators can present innovations with greater clarity and confidence for a higher chance of achieving their fundraising goals.

6.3. Conclusion and future works

This paper reframes crowdfunding performance through the lens of the creator. By treating the biography, avatar, and on-platform interaction as an integrated decision surface, we show that small, observable choices in how entrepreneurs present themselves systematically track with funding outcomes across diverse Kickstarter categories and a long-

time horizon. The contribution is not another list of “tips,” but an evidence-based account of how linguistic pragmatics, visual identity, and interactive behavior jointly structure the way backers form judgments under uncertainty. The approach to our findings is portable. The constructs are measurable at scale, comparable across projects, and interpretable by scholars and practitioners alike.

Some limitations deserve emphasis. First, we exclude zero-funded campaigns. These projects likely reflect distinct phenomena like network dynamics, platform policy noncompliance, or product/idea viability issues and merit separate study rather than being folded into the same behavioral assumptions. Second, our design is observational. Although we employ extensive campaign-level factor and robustness checks, the estimates remain associational. Causal identification will require experimental or quasi-experimental designs. Additional nuance also lies beyond our current measures since dictionary-based speech act detection may miss context, our automated avatar metric may underweight category- or culture-specific aesthetics, and our analysis is limited to one platform and a predominantly English environment. Third, this study focuses on the role of creator-level factors in the success of a campaign regardless of the project’s category.

Future studies could address the potential influence of the category on the project’s success. Randomized wording and avatar experiments, or platform-run A/B tests, could establish causality and boundary conditions. Cross-platform replications like in equity or donation crowdfunding, and cross-lingual extensions would probe external validity. Creator-level panels that track how bios evolve over a campaign could reveal dynamic strategy, while backer-level microdata could connect presentation choices to individual pledge behavior. Finally, evaluating creator-facing assistance tools in the field would test whether turning these measures into feedback improves outcomes, and for whom, surfacing important equity and fairness questions.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Gianluca Zanella: Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Methodology, Funding acquisition. **Pouria Rad:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Project administration, Methodology, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Mohsen Jozani:** Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Project administration, Methodology, Conceptualization. **Mohammadreza Meigounpoory:** Supervision.

Declaration of Generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the writing process

During the preparation of this work, the author(s) used OpenAI ChatGPT and Grammarly for the sole purpose of enhancing the readability and proofreading of the writing. All ideas and original work in the manuscript are the result of the authors’ efforts, and the author(s) reviewed and edited the content as needed, taking full responsibility for the content of this publication.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Appendix A. Correlation Matrix of Independent Variables (Pearson)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)	(11)	(12)	(13)	(14)	(15)	(16)	(17)	(18)	(19)	(20)
1.000																				
−0.131	1.000																			
−0.040	0.007	1.000																		
−0.026	0.055	0.067	1.000																	
−0.049	0.081	0.030	0.068	1.000																
−0.053	0.084	0.108	0.202	0.041	1.000															
−0.033	0.046	0.055	0.156	0.487	0.071	1.000														
−0.011	0.085	0.096	0.138	0.143	0.097	0.153	1.000													
−0.001	0.039	−0.001	0.097	0.068	0.037	0.088	0.275	1.000												
0.041	0.010	−0.011	−0.014	−0.010	−0.012	0.024	0.033	−0.015	1.000											
0.035	0.173	−0.029	0.037	0.162	0.070	0.092	−0.045	0.078	−0.004	1.000										
0.022	0.114	0.065	0.044	0.093	0.001	0.166	0.071	0.022	−0.003	−0.239	1.000									
−0.079	0.090	0.010	0.055	0.117	0.047	0.020	0.111	0.187	0.037	0.083	0.058	1.000								
0.005	0.041	0.034	0.010	0.052	−0.009	0.020	0.080	−0.005	0.260	−0.028	0.005	0.017	1.000							
−0.017	0.003	−0.009	−0.003	−0.027	0.014	−0.014	−0.007	0.160	−0.001	−0.012	−0.004	−0.014	−0.011	1.000						
−0.012	−0.005	0.009	0.015	0.007	0.004	0.020	0.053	0.018	0.002	−0.139	0.155	−0.006	0.005	0.003	1.000					
0.056	−0.024	−0.004	0.004	−0.014	−0.001	−0.031	−0.014	−0.010	0.008	0.013	−0.011	−0.004	0.012	−0.028	−0.079	1.000				
0.185	−0.020	−0.026	−0.002	−0.009	0.001	−0.027	−0.026	−0.008	0.021	0.015	−0.022	−0.031	0.012	0.004	−0.038	0.049	1.000			
0.304	−0.064	−0.025	0.002	−0.034	−0.037	−0.010	−0.012	0.001	0.042	0.025	0.008	−0.040	0.014	−0.014	−0.043	0.035	0.091	1.000		
0.045	0.010	−0.030	0.016	0.011	0.016	0.008	−0.013	−0.010	−0.022	0.125	−0.060	−0.005	−0.035	0.028	−0.040	0.026	0.058	0.006	1.000	

Appendix B. Campaign-level Factors Model Development

Initial Baseline Model						Final Baseline Model			
DV= log ₁₀ (Campaign Funding Ratio)	Coef.	Std. Err.	t-value	p-value	Stay in Model	Coef.	Std. Err.	t-value	p-value
Number of Rewards	0.039***	0.002	17.56	0.000	✓	0.041***	0.002	18.11	0.000
Number of Collaborators	0.085***	0.013	6.76	0.000	✓	0.076***	0.013	5.86	0.000
Number of Projects Created	0.020***	0.002	13.46	0.000	✓	0.023***	0.002	14.86	0.000
Number of Images	0.012***	0.001	11.96	0.000	✓	0.005***	0.001	4.89	0.000
Number of Videos	−0.042	0.006	−6.78	0.000		-	-	-	-
Funding Duration	−0.018***	0.001	−19.44	0.000	✓	−0.020***	0.001	−20.89	0.000
Location	0.632	0.028	22.34	0.000		-	-	-	-
Project Title Length	0.049***	0.005	10.73	0.000	✓	0.047***	0.005	10.10	0.000
Project Description Length	−0.027***	0.005	−13.32	0.000	✓	−0.033***	0.002	−15.62	0.000
Number of External Links	−0.847***	0.002	−29.85	0.000	✓	−0.994***	0.028	−34.95	0.000
Projects We Love Tag	0.261***	0.042	6.24	0.000	✓	0.255***	0.043	5.91	0.000
Number of Updates	0.038***	0.001	28.13	0.000	✓	0.041***	0.001	29.80	0.000
Number of FAQs	0.010***	0.003	2.92	0.003	✓	0.007**	0.004	1.85	0.042
Constant	−0.791***	0.058	−13.59	0.000		−0.147***	0.053	−2.78	0.005
Initial Baseline Model						Final Baseline Model			
R-squared	0.497	Adjusted R-squared		0.496	R-squared	0.464	Adjusted R-squared		0.463
Root MSE	1.072	Number of obs.		9150	Root MSE	1.107	Number of obs.		9150
F-test	693.280	Prob > F		0.000	F-test	718.482	Prob > F		0.000
Akaike crit. (AIC)	27257.354	Bayesian crit. (BIC)		27357.056	Akaike crit. (AIC)	27831.404	Bayesian crit. (BIC)		27916.862

*** $p < .01$, ** $p < .05$, * $p < .1$

Appendix C. Full OLS regression estimates for hierarchical models

DV = $\log_{10}$ (Campaign Funding Ratio)	Baseline model (Campaign-level factors only)	Speech Acts model (H1 and H2)	Visual Credibility model (H3 and H4)	Social Engagement model (H5, H6 and H7)	Full Model (Creator-level + Campaign-level factors)
Number of Rewards	0.041*** (0.00)	0.041*** (0.00)	0.041*** (0.00)	0.040*** (0.00)	0.040*** (0.00)
Number of Collaborators	0.076*** (0.01)	0.076*** (0.01)	0.078*** (0.01)	0.047*** (0.01)	0.051*** (0.01)
Number of Projects Created	0.023*** (0.00)	0.024*** (0.00)	0.023*** (0.00)	0.022*** (0.00)	0.023*** (0.00)
Number of Images	0.005*** (0.00)	0.005*** (0.00)	0.005*** (0.00)	0.006*** (0.00)	0.006*** (0.00)
Funding Duration	-0.020*** (0.00)	-0.020*** (0.00)	-0.020*** (0.00)	-0.019*** (0.00)	-0.019*** (0.00)
Project Title Length	0.047*** (0.01)	0.047*** (0.01)	0.048*** (0.01)	-0.046*** (0.01)	0.046*** (0.01)
Project Description Length	-0.033*** (0.00)	-0.030*** (0.00)	-0.032*** (0.00)	-0.031*** (0.00)	-0.029*** (0.00)
Number of External Links	-0.994*** (0.03)	-0.963*** (0.03)	-0.991*** (0.03)	-0.922*** (0.03)	-0.896*** (0.03)
Projects We Love Tag	0.255*** (0.04)	0.255*** (0.04)	0.251*** (0.04)	0.214*** (0.04)	0.213*** (0.04)
Number of Updates	0.041*** (0.00)	0.040*** (0.00)	0.041*** (0.00)	0.038*** (0.00)	0.038*** (0.00)
Number of FAQs	0.007*** (0.00)	0.007*** (0.00)	0.007*** (0.00)	0.006*** (0.00)	0.007*** (0.00)
Comm. Speech Act Need	—	-4.929*** (0.65)	—	—	-4.620*** (0.64)
Comm. Speech Act Goal	—	-0.871 (1.05)	—	—	—
Comm. Speech Act Try	—	-0.582 (0.57)	—	—	—
Comm. Speech Act Means	—	-0.753* (0.39)	—	—	-0.893*** (0.34)
Comm. Speech Act Persist	—	-2.109* (1.13)	—	—	-2.242** (1.12)
Comm. Speech Act Complete	—	-0.917 (0.59)	—	—	—
Comm. Speech Act Virtue	—	0.286 (0.29)	—	—	—
Expr. Speech Act PosAff	—	-0.133 (0.57)	—	—	—
Expr. Speech Act NegAff	—	4.999*** (1.66)	—	—	4.314*** (1.59)
Expr. Speech Act Self	—	1.462*** (0.25)	—	—	1.235*** (0.24)
Expr. Speech Act Our	—	2.172*** (0.44)	—	—	2.035*** (0.43)
Expr. Speech Act Intrj.	—	-5.021*** (0.92)	—	—	-4.642*** (0.89)
Expr. Speech Act Vice	—	0.199 (0.72)	—	—	—
Expr. Speech Act Feel	—	-2.905 (2.57)	—	—	—
Having a Logo	—	—	-0.640*** (0.02)	—	-0.052*** (0.02)
Avatar Quality	—	—	0.048*** (0.01)	—	0.043*** (0.01)
Number of Projects backed	—	—	—	0.001*** (0.00)	0.001*** (0.00)
Creator Comment Response Ratio	—	—	—	1.069*** (0.08)	1.011*** (0.08)
Social Media Integration	—	—	—	0.016 (0.02)	—
Constant	-0.147***	-0.179***	-0.130***	-0.288***	-0.285***
Observation	9150	9150	9150	9150	9150
F-test	277.230***	326.212***	611.522***	593.448***	389.340***
Adjusted R-squared	0.463	0.471	0.465	0.476	0.483
Hypothesis ?	—	H1: ×, H2: ✓	H3: ×, H4: ✓	H5: × ✓, H6: × ✓, H7: ×	—
Standard errors in parentheses; *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$					

Appendix D. Variance Inflation Factor of Full Model (Creator-level + Campaign-level Factors)

	VIF	1/VIF
Number of Updates	1.372	0.729
Number of FAQs	1.332	0.751
Number of External Links	1.307	0.765
Number of Images	1.270	0.788
Number of Projects Created	1.240	0.806
Expr. Speech Act Self	1.234	0.810
Number of Collaborators	1.218	0.821
Creator Comment Response Ratio	1.158	0.863
Expr. Speech Act Our	1.148	0.871
Number of Projects Backed	1.142	0.876
Project Description Length	1.139	0.878
Funding Duration	1.135	0.881
Projects We Love Tag	1.126	0.888
Number of Rewards	1.122	0.892
Project Title Length	1.106	0.904
Comm. Speech Act Need	1.086	0.921
Having a Logo	1.072	0.933
Comm. Speech Act Means	1.069	0.935
Expr. Speech Act Intrj.	1.039	0.962
Comm. Speech Act Persist	1.017	0.983
Avatar Quality	1.015	0.986
Expr. Speech Act NegAff	1.005	0.995
Mean VIF	1.152	—

Data Availability

Data will be made available on request.

References

- Adamska-Mieruszewska, J., Mrzygłód, U., Suchanek, M., & Fornalska-Skurczyńska, A. (2021). Keep it simple. The impact of language on crowdfunding success. *SOCIOLOGICAL RESEARCH Economics & Sociology*, 14(1), 130–144. <https://doi.org/10.14254/2071>
- Aditria, N., Rizqiya, R. S., & Siliwangi, I. (2021). A speech act analysis of written advertisement of cosmetic brand in Indonesia, 4(4). (<https://www.instagram.com/p/B8d2XqenJXN/?igshid=1a2r9149nuwff>).
- Agrawal, A., Catalini, C., & Goldfarb, A. (2015). Crowdfunding: Geography, social networks, and the timing of investment decisions. *In Journal of Economics and Management Strategy*, 24(2), 253–274. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jems.12093>
- Alhammad, M. M., Tan, C., Alsarhani, N., & Zolkepli, I. A. (2022). What impacts backers' behavior to fund reward-based crowdfunding projects? A Systematic review study. *Pacific Asia Journal of the Association for Information Systems*, 14(2), 90–110. <https://doi.org/10.17705/1pais.14207>
- Amaefula, U. P. (2022). An Analysis of The Speech Acts in Advertisement Slogans.
- Anglin, A. H., Short, J. C., Drover, W., Stevenson, R. M., McKenny, A. F., & Allison, T. H. (2018). The power of positivity? The influence of positive psychological capital language on crowdfunding performance. *Journal of Business Venturing*, 33(4), 470–492.
- Ansari, S., & Gupta, S. (2021). Customer perception of the deceptiveness of online product reviews: A speech act theory perspective. *International Journal of Information Management*, 57. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijinfomgt.2020.102286>
- Argyris, Y. A., Monu, K., Kim, Y., Zhou, Y., Wang, Z., & Yin, Z. (2021). Using Speech Acts to Elicit Positive Emotions for Complainers on Social Media. *Journal of Interactive Marketing*, 55, 67–80. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.intmar.2021.02.001>
- Austin, J. L., & Warnock, G. J. (1962). *Sense and sensibilia*, 83. Clarendon Press Oxford.
- Bakshi, S., Shamma, D. A., & Gilbert, E. (2014). Faces engage us: Photos with faces attract more likes and comments on instagram. *Proceedings of the SIGCHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, 965–974.
- Bandura, A., & Cervone, D. (1986). Differential engagement of self-reactive influences in cognitive motivation. *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes*, 38(1), 92–113.
- Belleflamme, P., Lambert, T., & Schwienbacher, A. (2014). Crowdfunding: Tapping the right crowd. *Journal of Business Venturing*, 29(5), 585–609.
- Bernardino, S., & Santos, J. F. (2020). Crowdfunding: an exploratory study on knowledge, benefits and barriers perceived by young potential entrepreneurs. *Journal of Risk and Financial Management*, 13(4), 81.
- Bernstein, S., Korteweg, A., & Laws, K. (2017). Attracting early-stage investors: Evidence from a randomized field experiment. *The Journal of Finance*, 72(2), 509–538.
- Bi, S., Liu, Z., & Usman, K. (2017). The influence of online information on investing decisions of reward-based crowdfunding. *Journal of Business Research*, 71, 10–18, 10–18.
- Blue, P. R., Hu, J., Peng, L., Yu, H., Liu, H., & Zhou, X. (2020). Whose promises are worth more? How social status affects trust in promises. *European Journal of Social Psychology*, 50(1), 189–206.
- Borst, I., Moser, C., & Ferguson, J. (2018). From friendfunding to crowdfunding: Relevance of relationships, social media, and platform activities to crowdfunding performance. *New Media Society*, 20(4), 1396–1414.
- Broder, P., & Remers, E. (2018). Eye contact and trust online: the effect of profile pictures on Airbnb booking. *2018 IEEE 12th International Conference on Application of Information and Communication Technologies (AICT)*, 1–4.
- Burt, R. S. (2000). The network structure of social capital. *Research in Organizational Behavior*, 22, 345–423.
- Burtch, G., Ghose, A., & Wattal, S. (2013). An empirical examination of the antecedents and consequences of contribution patterns in crowd-funded markets. *Information Systems Research*, 24(3), 499–519.
- Cappa, F., Pinelli, M., Maiolini, R., & Leone, M. I. (2021). “Pledge” me your ears! The role of narratives and narrator experience in explaining crowdfunding success. *Small Business Economics*, 57(2), 953–973.
- Chaichi, N. (2021). Portland State University. *Perceived Value of Technology Product Features by Crowdfunding Backers: The Case of 3D Printing Technology on Kickstarter Platform*.
- Chen, A., Zhang, Y., Liu, Y., & Lu, Y. (2023). Be a good speaker in livestream shopping: A speech act theory perspective. *Electronic Commerce Research and Applications*, 61. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.elerap.2023.101301>
- Chen, S., Wang, H., Fang, Y., & Wang, W. (2023). Informational and emotional appeals of cover image in crowdfunding platforms and the moderating role of campaign outputs. *Decision Support Systems*, 171. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.dss.2023.113975>
- Cialdini, R. B. (1993). Influence: The Psychology of Persuasion. *Angewandte Chemie International Edition*, 6(11), 951–952.
- Colombo, M. G., Franzoni, C., & Rossi-Lamastra, C. (2015). Internal social capital and the attraction of early contributions in crowdfunding. *Entrepreneurship Theory and Practice*, 39(1), 75–100.
- Cordova, A., Dolci, J., & Gianfrate, G. (2015). The Determinants of Crowdfunding Success: Evidence from Technology Projects. *Procedia - Social and Behavioral Sciences*, 181, 115–124. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.sbspro.2015.04.872>
- Courtney, C., Dutta, S., & Li, Y. (2017). Resolving information asymmetry: Signaling, endorsement, and crowdfunding success. *Entrepreneurship Theory and Practice*, 41(2), 265–290.
- Cramer, D. (2003). *Advanced quantitative data analysis*. UK: McGraw-Hill Education.
- Defazio, D., Franzoni, C., & Rossi-Lamastra, C. (2021). How pro-social framing affects the success of crowdfunding projects: The role of emphasis and information crowdedness. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 171, 357–378.
- Duan, Y., Hsieh, T. S., Wang, R. R., & Wang, Z. (2020). Entrepreneurs' facial trustworthiness, gender, and crowdfunding success. *Journal of Corporate Finance*, 64 (July), Article 101693. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jcorpfin.2020.101693>
- Elkhdhir, K. M. F. (2017). Reward-based crowdfunding technological projects determinants of success: A quantitative study. *The Journal of Entrepreneurial Finance*, 19(2), 1–25.
- Gabay-Mariani, L. (2022). Measuring nascent entrepreneurs' commitment: The conceptualization, measurement and proposition of an integrative model. *Revue Délelôtt L'Entrepreneuriat/Review of Entrepreneurship*, 21, (3), 47–78.
- Gabay-Mariani, L., Bastian, B., Caputo, A., & Pappas, N. (2024). Hidden stories and the dark side of entrepreneurial commitment. *International Journal of Entrepreneurial Behavior Research*, 30(6), 1553–1575.
- Gerber, E. M., & Hui, J. (2013). Crowdfunding: Motivations and deterrents for participation. *ACM Transactions on Computer-Human Interaction*, 20(6), 1–32.
- Gerber, E. M., Hui, J. S., & Kuo, P.-Y. (2012). Crowdfunding: Why people are motivated to post and fund projects on crowdfunding platforms. *Proc of the International Workshop on ...*, February. (http://juliehui.org/wp-content/uploads/2013/04/CSCW_Crowdfunding_Final.pdf), 10.
- Ghobadi, S. (2023). Communication of post-release plans in crowdfunding development initiatives: A signaling perspective. *International Journal of Information Management*, 69, Article 102592. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijinfomgt.2022.102592>
- Giddens, A. (1985). *Les conséquences Délelôtt Louisiana modernité*.
- Guo, Q., Zhou, S., Wu, Y., Peng, Z., & Ma, X. (2022). Understanding and modeling viewers' first impressions with images in online medical crowdfunding campaigns. *Proceedings of the 2022 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, 1–20.
- Hohen, S., Hüning, C., & Schweizer, L. (2025). Reward-based crowdfunding—A systematic literature review. *Management Review Quarterly*, 1–48.
- Hopp, C., Rose, S., & Kaminski, J. (2022). The pervasive role of campaign and product-related uncertainties in inhibiting crowdfunding success. *Journal of Risk and Financial Management*, 15(8), 370.
- Hsieh, H.-C., Hsieh, Y.-C., & Vu, T. H. C. (2019). How social movements influence crowdfunding success. *Pacific-Basin Finance Journal*, 53, 308–320, 308–320.
- Janson, M. A., & Woo, C. C. (1996). A speech act lexicon: An alternative use of speech act theory in information systems. *Information Systems Journal*, 6(4), 301–329.
- Jia, L., Zhang, Y., & Lin, C. (2024). Social interaction and the successful exit of cultural and creative crowdfunding projects: evidence from the Modian platform. *Information Technology People*, 37(4), 1478–1513. <https://doi.org/10.1108/ITP-08-2022-0616>
- Johnston, T. (2013). Towards a comparative semiotics of pointing actions in signed and spoken languages. *Gesture*, 13(2), 109–142.
- Jozani, M., Balapour, A., & Safaei Pour, M. (2022). Crowdfunding Project Success for Game Developers: Evidence from Kickstarter and Steam. *Proceedings of the 55th Hawaii International Conference on System Sciences*. <https://doi.org/10.24251/hicss.2022.536>
- Jozani, M., Liu, C. Z., & Choo, K.-K. R. (2023). An empirical study of content-based recommendation systems in mobile app markets. *Decision Support Systems*, 169, Article 113954.
- Kim, P. H., Buffart, M., & Croidieu, G. (2016). TMI: Signaling credible claims in crowdfunding campaign narratives. *Group Organization Management*, 41(6), 717–750.
- Koch, J. A., & Cheng, Q. (2016). The role of qualitative success factors in the analysis of crowdfunding success: Evidence from kickstarter. *Pacific Asia Conference on Information Systems, PACIS 2016 - Proceedings*, June.
- Kuppuswamy, V., & Bayus, B. L. (2018a). Crowdfunding creative ideas: The dynamics of project backers. In D & H. L (Eds.), C (pp. 151–182). The Economics of Crowdfunding. Palgrave Macmillan, Cham. Title: Crowdfunding creative ideas. The dynamics of project backers Author: Kuppuswamy, V. Author: Bayus, B. L. Journal title: The Economics of Crowdfunding Pages: 151-182 Publication date: 2018.
- Kuppuswamy, V., & Bayus, B. L. (2018b). Crowdfunding Creative Ideas: The dynamics of project backers. In *The Economics of Crowdfunding: Startups, Portals and Investor Behavior*. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-319-66119-3_8
- Lee, J., & Hong, I. B. (2016). Predicting positive user responses to social media advertising: The roles of emotional appeal, informativeness, and creativity. *International Journal of Information Management*, 36(3), 360–373. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijinfomgt.2016.01.001>
- Lowry, P. B., Wilson, D. W., & Haig, W. L. (2014). A picture is worth a thousand words: Source credibility theory applied to logo and website design for heightened credibility and consumer trust. *International Journal of Human-Computer Interaction*, 30(1), 63–93.
- Ludwig, S., & de Ruyter, K. (2016). Decoding social media speak: developing a speech act theory research agenda. *Journal of Consumer Marketing*, 33(2), 124–134. <https://doi.org/10.1108/JCM-04-2015-1405>
- Mahmood, A., Luffarelli, J., & Mukesh, M. (2019). What's in a logo? The impact of complex visual cues in equity crowdfunding. *Journal of Business Venturing*, 34(1), 41–62. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusvent.2018.09.006>
- Messeni Petruzzelli, A., Natalicchio, A., Panniello, U., & Roma, P. (2019). Understanding the crowdfunding phenomenon and its implications for sustainability. *Technological Forecasting and Social Change*, 141(October 2017), 138–148. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.techfore.2018.10.002>

- Mitra, T., & Gilbert, E. (2014). The language that gets people to give: Phrases that predict success on kickstarter. *Proceedings of the 17th ACM Conference on Computer Supported Cooperative Work Social Computing*, 49–61.
- Mollick, E. (2014). The dynamics of crowdfunding: An exploratory study. *Journal of Business Venturing*, 29(1), 1–16. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusvent.2013.06.005>
- Mollick, E., & Kuppupswamy, V. (2016). *Crowdfunding: Evidence on the democratization of Start-up Funding*.
- Mollick, E. R. (2012). The Dynamics of Crowdfunding: Determinants of Success and Failure. *SSRN Electronic Journal*. <https://doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.2088298>
- Obiora, S. C., & Csordás, T. (2017). The Case of Alternative Versus Traditional Financing: A Literature Review. *Archives of Business Research*, 5(9). <https://doi.org/10.14738/abr.59.3581>
- Parhankangas, A., & Renko, M. (2017). Linguistic style and crowdfunding success among social and commercial entrepreneurs. *Journal of Business Venturing*, 32(2), 215–236.
- Paxton, P., Velasco, K., & Ressler, R. W. (2020). Does use of emotion increase donations and volunteers for nonprofits? *American Sociological Review*, 85(6), 1051–1083.
- Pennebaker, J. W., Francis, M. E., & Roger, J. B. (1999). Linguistic Inquiry and Word Count (LIWC). *Applied Natural Language Processing, January 1999*, 206–229. <https://doi.org/10.4018/978-1-60960-741-8.ch012>
- Poetz, M. K., & Schreier, M. (2012). The value of crowdsourcing: Can users really compete with professionals in generating new product ideas? *Journal of Product Innovation Management*, 29(2), 245–256. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1540-5885.2011.00893.x>
- Rieglensberger, J., & Angela Sasse, M. (2001). Trustbuilders and trustbusters: The role of trust cues in interfaces to e-commerce applications. In *Towards the E-Society: E-commerce, E-business, and E-government* (pp. 17–30). Springer.
- Roberts, A. J. (2013). How to do things with word marks: a speech-act theory of distinctiveness. *Ala L Rev*, 65, 1035.
- Searle, J. R. (1969). *Speech acts: An essay in the philosophy of language* (Vol. 626). Cambridge university press.
- Septianasari, L., Baihaqi, Y., Abqoriyyah, F. H., & Syaputri, W. (2021). Language of persuasion in online marketing of cosmetic products: A glance of Netnography in pragmatics. *PRASASTI: Journal of Linguistics*, 6(1), 74–85.
- Shi, B., Wang, N., & Li, Q. (2023). How Characteristics of Creator and Campaign Shape Crowdfunding Performance: Using Hierarchical Linear Modeling. In Y. Tu, & M. Chi (Eds.), *E-Business. Digital Empowerment for an Intelligent Future* (pp. 228–237). Springer Nature Switzerland.
- Singer, A. E. (2023). Marketing objects as talking machines: The performative capacity of product packages. *Marketing Theory*, 14705931231207320. <https://doi.org/10.1177/14705931231207319>
- Small, D. A., & Verrochi, N. M. (2009). The face of need: Facial emotion expression on charity advertisements. *Journal of Marketing Research*, 46(6), 777–787.
- Kickstarter. (2025). *Kickstarter Stats*. Kickstarter. (<https://www.kickstarter.com/help/stats>).
- Steinbrück, U., Schaumburg, H., Duda, S., & Krüger, T. (2002). A picture says more than a thousand words: photographs as trust builders in e-commerce websites. *CHI '02 Extended Abstracts on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, 748–749.
- Strausz, R. (2017). A theory of crowdfunding: A mechanism design approach with demand uncertainty and moral hazard. *American Economic Review*, 107(6), 1430–1476. <https://doi.org/10.1257/aer.20151700>
- STRIZHKOVA, O. V., KABANOVA, O. V., SHCHERBAKOVA, M. V., TEREKHOVA, G. V., & MOKRICKAYA, E. A. (2018). The main features of speech acts usage in food advertising discourse. *Revista ESPACIOS*, 39, 36.
- Thies, F., Wessel, M., Rudolph, J., & Benlian, A. (2016). Personality matters: How signaling personality traits can influence the adoption and diffusion of crowdfunding campaigns. In T. Istanbul (Ed.), *the Twenty-Fourth European Conference on Information Systems (ECIS2016)*. Title: *Personality matters: How signaling personality traits can influence the adoption and diffusion of crowdfunding campaigns* Author: Thies, F. Author: Wessel, M. Author: Rudolph, J. Author: Benlian, A. Journal title: In the Twenty-Fourth European Conf.
- Todorov, A., Olivola, C. Y., Dotsch, R., & Mende-Siedlecki, P. (2015). Social attributions from faces: Determinants, consequences, accuracy, and functional significance. *Annual Review of Psychology*, 66(1), 519–545.
- Tosatto, J., Cox, J., & Nguyen, T. (2022). With a little help from my friends: The role of online creator-fan communication channels in the success of creative crowdfunding campaigns. *Computers in Human Behavior*, 127, Article 107005.
- Troise, C., Tani, M., & Jones, P. (2020). Investigating the impact of multidimensional social capital on equity crowdfunding performance. *International Journal of Information Management*, 55, Article 102230. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijinfomgt.2020.102230>
- Viola, P., & Jones, M. (2001). Rapid object detection using a boosted cascade of simple features. *Proceedings of the 2001 IEEE Computer Society Conference on Computer Vision and Pattern Recognition CVPR 2001*, 1, 1–I.
- Wang, F., Xu, H., Hou, R., & Zhu, Z. (2023). Designing marketing content for social commerce to drive consumer purchase behaviors: A perspective from speech act theory. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*, 70. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretconser.2022.103156>
- Wang, N., Li, Q., Liang, H., Ye, T., & Ge, S. (2018). Understanding the importance of interaction between creators and backers in crowdfunding success. *Electronic Commerce Research and Applications*, 27, 106–117.
- Wang, W., Chen, W., Zhu, K., & Wang, H. (2020). Emphasizing the entrepreneur or the idea? The impact of text content emphasis on investment decisions in crowdfunding. *Decision Support Systems*, 136, Article 113341.
- Wu, T.-Y., & Li, Y.-M. (2023). Exploring the Role of Social Identity and Semantic Traits in the Success of the Creator Economy. *14th IIAI International Congress on Advanced Applied Informatics (IIAI-AAI)*, 2023, 53–56.
- Yang, J., Li, Y., Calic, G., & Shevchenko, A. (2020). How multimedia shape crowdfunding outcomes: The overshadowing effect of images and videos on text in campaign information. *Journal of Business Research*, 117, 6–18.
- Yuan, H., Lau, R. Y. K., & Xu, W. (2016). The determinants of crowdfunding success: A semantic text analytics approach. *Decision Support Systems*, 91, 67–76. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.dss.2016.08.001>
- Zanella, G., & Renard, S. (2022). Entrepreneurship engagement in the arts: The role of incubators and social media influencers. *Journal of Enterprising. Culture*, 30(03), 321–341.
- Zheng, H., Li, D., Wu, J., & Xu, Y. (2014). The role of multidimensional social capital in crowdfunding: A comparative study in China and US. *Information and Management*, 51(4), 488–496. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.im.2014.03.003>
- Zhou, M., Lu, B., Fan, W., & Wang, G. A. (2018). Project description and crowdfunding success: an exploratory study. *Information Systems Frontiers*, 20, 259–274.
- Zhou, Y., Cui, J., & Wang, N. (2022). Do backers prefer crowdfunding or pre-order? An empirical study. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 13, Article 984775.
- Zribi, S., & Khoufi, W. (2022). Signalling Strategy and Success of Crowdfunding Campaign. *International Journal of Business and Society*, 23(3), 1921–1938.

Mohammadreza Meigounpoory, Ph.D., is a faculty member at the Faculty of Entrepreneurship, University of Tehran, Iran, and the Founder and president of the *New Product Development and Commercialization Management Research Center* (NPDCM RC). His research interests include crowdfunding, innovation, technological entrepreneurship, and new product design and development. He has authored numerous journal articles and conference papers in these areas.

Pouria Rad, is a researcher driven by curiosity about how people and intelligent systems shape one another. He is a Ph.D. student in Computer and Information Sciences in the School of Computer and Cyber Sciences at Augusta University, where his work spans artificial intelligence, information systems, cybersecurity, digital forensics, and platform governance. His projects focus on digital trust, creator credibility, and the ways technology influences behavior and decision-making in online environments. Pouria has collaborated on interdisciplinary research teams across computer science, security, and information systems. He has presented his work at venues such as *TechNet Augusta*, *HICSS*, *IEEE BSN*, *AMCIS*, and *ARES*. His research has been recognized with multiple awards, including Best Paper at *ARES ICS-CSR* and first place in the Ph.D. student research competition at *RSTCON*. Outside of publication and review cycles, he works closely with faculty collaborators to study how platforms, security controls, and human judgment interact in high-stakes digital settings.

Mohsen Jozani, Ph.D., is an assistant professor at San Diego State University's Fowler College of Business. Jozani received his PhD in Information Technology in 2020 from The University of Texas at San Antonio. He employs a multidisciplinary approach in his research, utilizing machine learning and econometric models to investigate user behavior on digital platforms. His research also delves into topics such as information processing in online forums, and privacy and security of information systems. His scholarly articles have been published in reputable peer-reviewed journals like *Decision Support Systems*, *IEEE Transactions on Big Data*, and *Computers in Human Behavior*.

Gianluca Zanella, Ph.D., is a curious scientist constantly looking for challenges and innovation. Fueled by a rich background that merges physics, management, and computer science, his journey includes driving robots in nuclear power plants, leading IT teams in the healthcare industry, and being a researcher and a faculty at the Augusta University, Georgia. His main research interests are applied AI and the human factor in cybersecurity education and operations. As an instructor, he enjoys sharing with the students his passion for technological innovation and mentoring student researchers in the early stages of their journey. In the free time, Gianluca is an avid reader of scientific publications and enjoys following the new trends in deep learning and natural language processing methodologies. He loves outdoor activities, such as gardening and golfing and he is a proud handyman constantly looking for new projects at home.